

Cover Page

This is a quick concept art of how the cover of the game would look like. It still needs to be in the correct style, which will be further explained later.

THROUGH THEIR EYES



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Game Summary

Through Their Eyes is a Narrative Adventure-Roguelike game that follows the story of a kid with social anxiety. It explores the themes of how kids face their fears and how they perceive the world as hostile when they do not understand it. Navigate through the school and explore its secrets to unveil the mysteries of your mind.

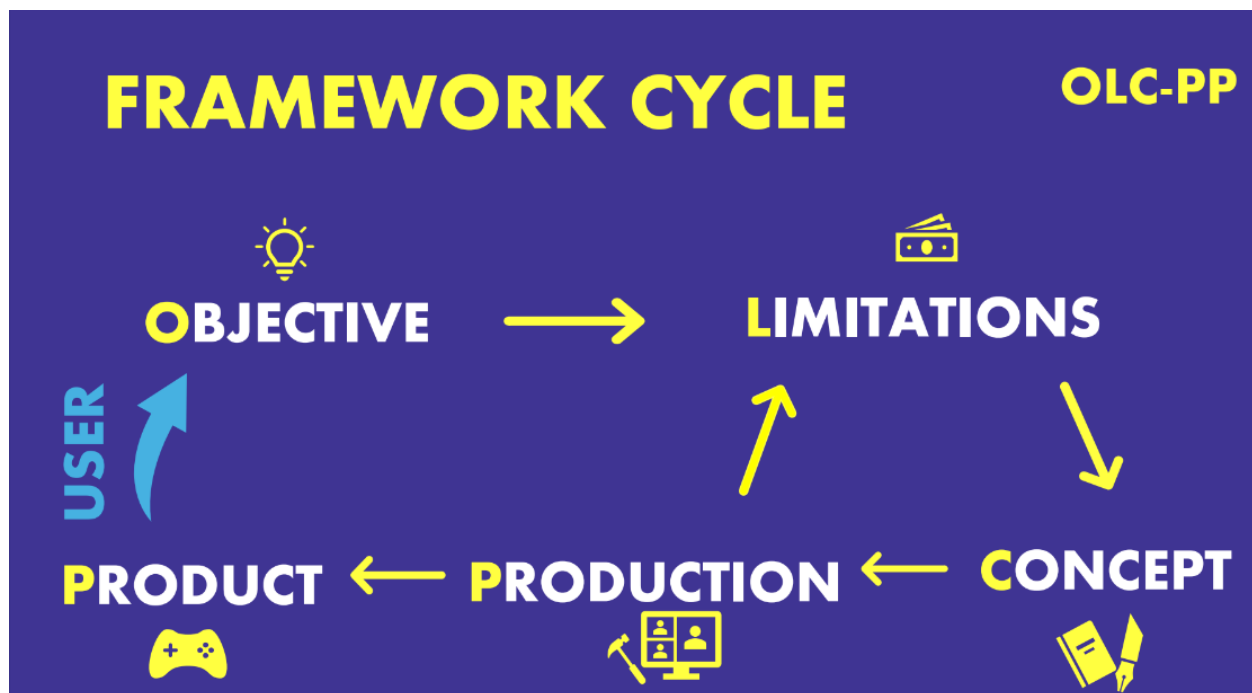
Framework

The framework used for the development of Through their Eyes has been the GOAL Framework. With this framework we look for the correct development of the game, starting from a clear idea. In this case, it has been the hybridization of the **Narrative Adventure** and **Roguelike** genres. Another of the most relevant aspects to take into account when planning the development of the game is to consider the limitations that will be faced throughout the process, from economic constraints to possible incidents that delay the development.

Once the possible limitations have been assessed, the cost of the game and the time it will take to develop it can be estimated in an approximate but realistic way. With this information you can move on to the Concept phase, in which the content of the game should be captured. Here all the aspects that will make up the game should be reflected in detail. From the mechanics, the items and the story, to the sensations that you want to evoke in the player. All this will facilitate the structuring, information search and development of the production phase. And in case something needs to be modified, it will be easy.

The production phase refers to the whole process of creating the final product, where everything stipulated in the Concept phase will be embodied. In this phase it is imperative that playtesting sessions are carried out and that all the elements are working as expected. If this is not the case, that section will be taken and will go through the Limitations process again to detect what the problem is and see if anything needs to be readjusted. It is then taken to the Concept phase where it will be redesigned and integrated back together with everything else, thus returning to the Production phase and resuming product development.

The Product phase corresponds to the finished product ready for release. What is expected is that everything works correctly, since it has been tested and redesigned as many times as necessary. But the most important point of all is that the initial objective has been transmitted to the users.



The following image portrays how the GOAL FRAMEWORK works.

Technical Sheet - Game Summary and Key Game Data

- Complete product summary: where the most fundamental aspects of the game

are discussed in more detail, but in an unified way.

Objectives of the game

- Face the fears (how imagination plays tricks on people).
- Upgrade stats to reach the required level to interact with NPCs.
- Advance through the level without succumbing to stress.
- Learn how to communicate with the world that surrounds the player and how each character needs different ways of communication.
- Unlock all characters and game endings.

Theme

Narrative Adventure fused with a **Roguelike**, set in a school of young kids seen through the eyes and imagination of one of them with social anxiety. This world is distorted because of this reason and there's different ways of solving this social dilemma through the decisions of the player.

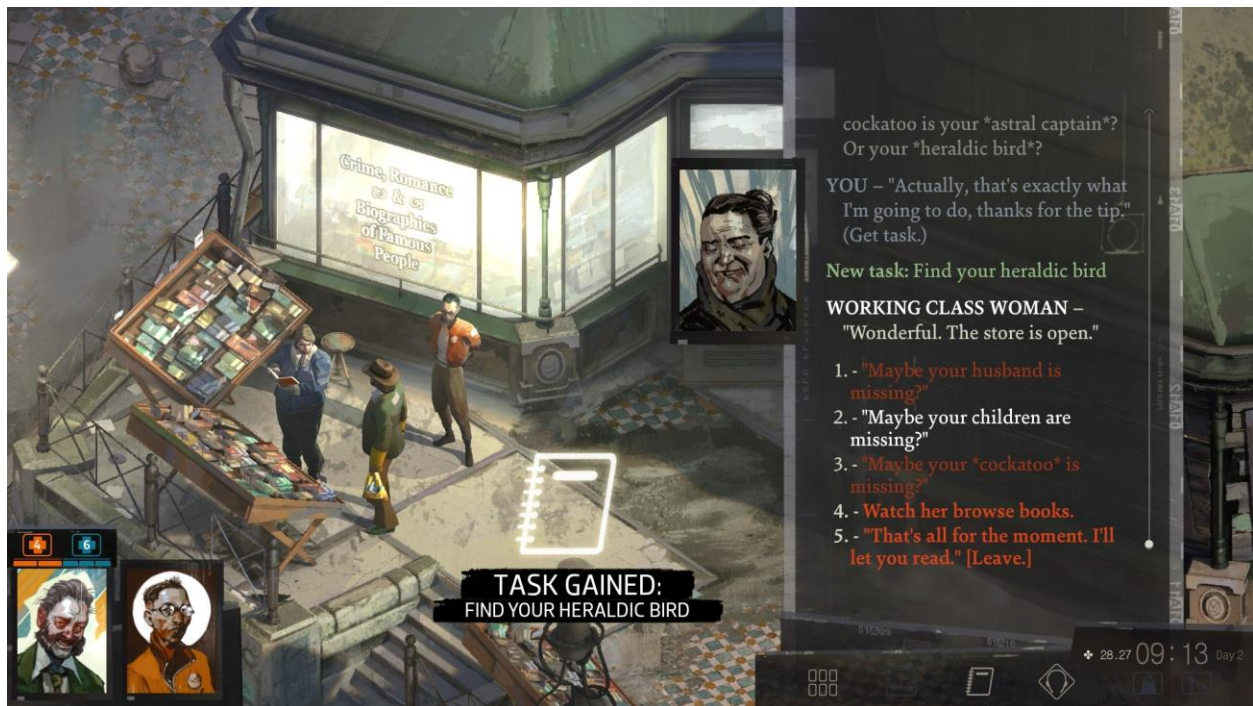
USP

- Turn-based **Roguelike** gameplay.
- Horror themed.
- Dynamic narrative and alternative routes to finish the game.
- Dealing with social dilemmas.
- For multiple audiences.

References

Story

To create and develop the story during the gameplay, numerous games were used as references, one of these being **Disco Elysium**. From this game, it was extracted how the narrative flows throughout the story according to the gameplay. Another detail to highlight is that the story goes deep and has many layers that give the player a lot of freedom to choose the path they want to follow. This story, depending on how much the player talks and investigates, unlocks numerous quests that another player may not have discovered. And this is exactly what the story of Through Their Eyes is all about, that the player investigates and discovers new paths.



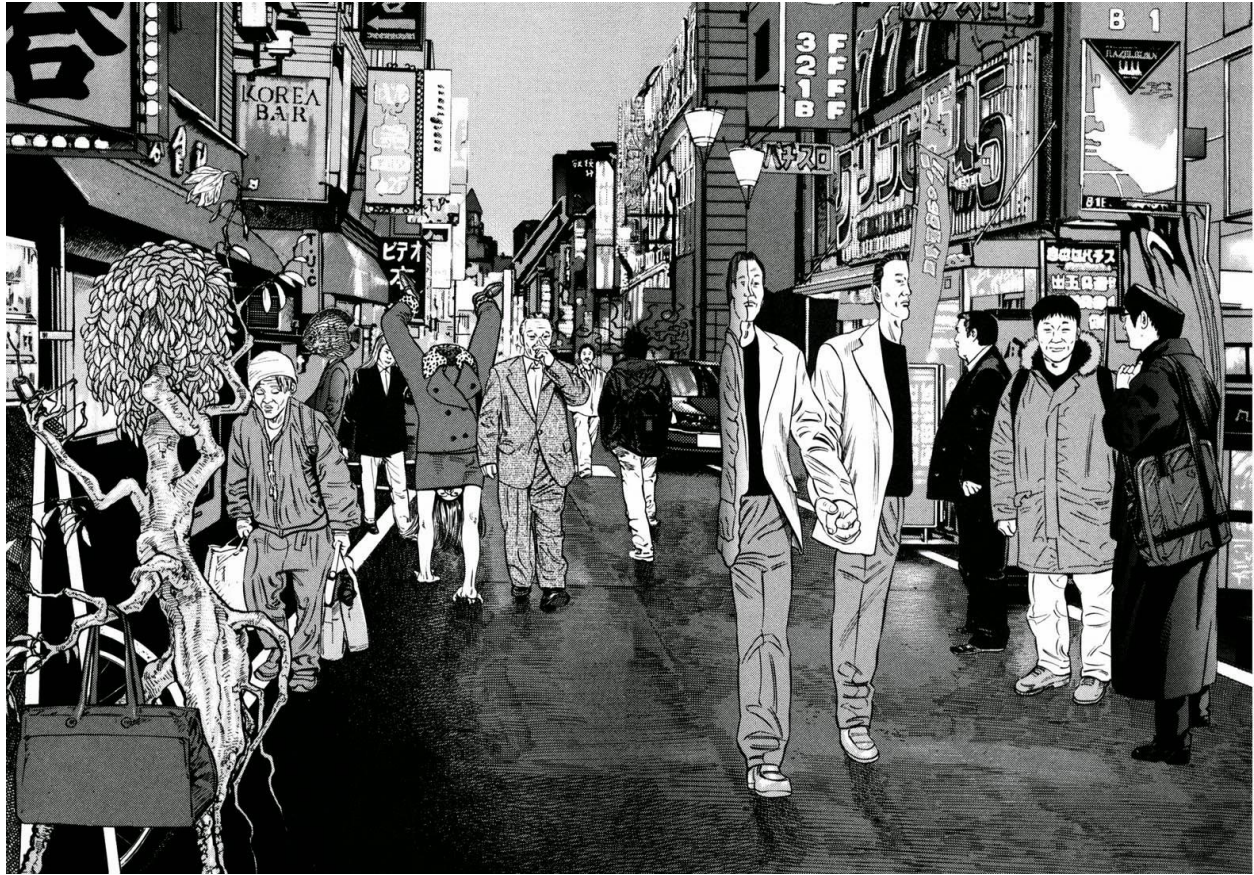
In Disco Elysium we can see how dialogue creates new quests.

Another reference is **Omori**, because in this game the protagonist lives something similar to Through Their Eyes. A child who lives in his imagination to deal with emotional problems that arise in reality. In addition, in this game, the protagonist **Omori** is also surrounded by friends who help him overcome these adversities.



In Omori, the player faces the imagination of the protagonist with his friends.

In order to bring out a richer and more engaging narrative, it was decided to look at other guilds outside of video games. It was decided to take inspiration from the **Homunculus** manga, where the protagonist sees people in warped versions of themselves. And, as in Through Their Eyes, the protagonist sees reality deformed due to emotional and social problems that different people experience.



The protagonist sees reality deformed by his mind.

Then, one of the most important parts of the story is to evoke the feeling of being a small child in a hostile world. For this, it was decided to use the **Little Nightmares** saga and the **Reanimal** as a reference to evoke this feeling. In the example of the Little Nightmares saga, the player takes control of Six. A girl who, in the first instalment of this saga, tries to escape from an iron box full of enemies trying to trap her. And, in the second instalment, the player takes on the role of Mono, who tries to rescue Six from a terrible fate. Throughout these two journeys, both protagonists are children in environments where they are constantly threatened by environmental situations, enemies and the very fact that they are completely alone. It is precisely all these emotions and sensations that are sought for Through Their Eyes, environments where the player feels the loneliness and danger that the protagonist lives due to the imagination. And how, through courage and friends, they can overcome adversity and learn from it.



Mono faces enemies to rescue Six from the enemies.

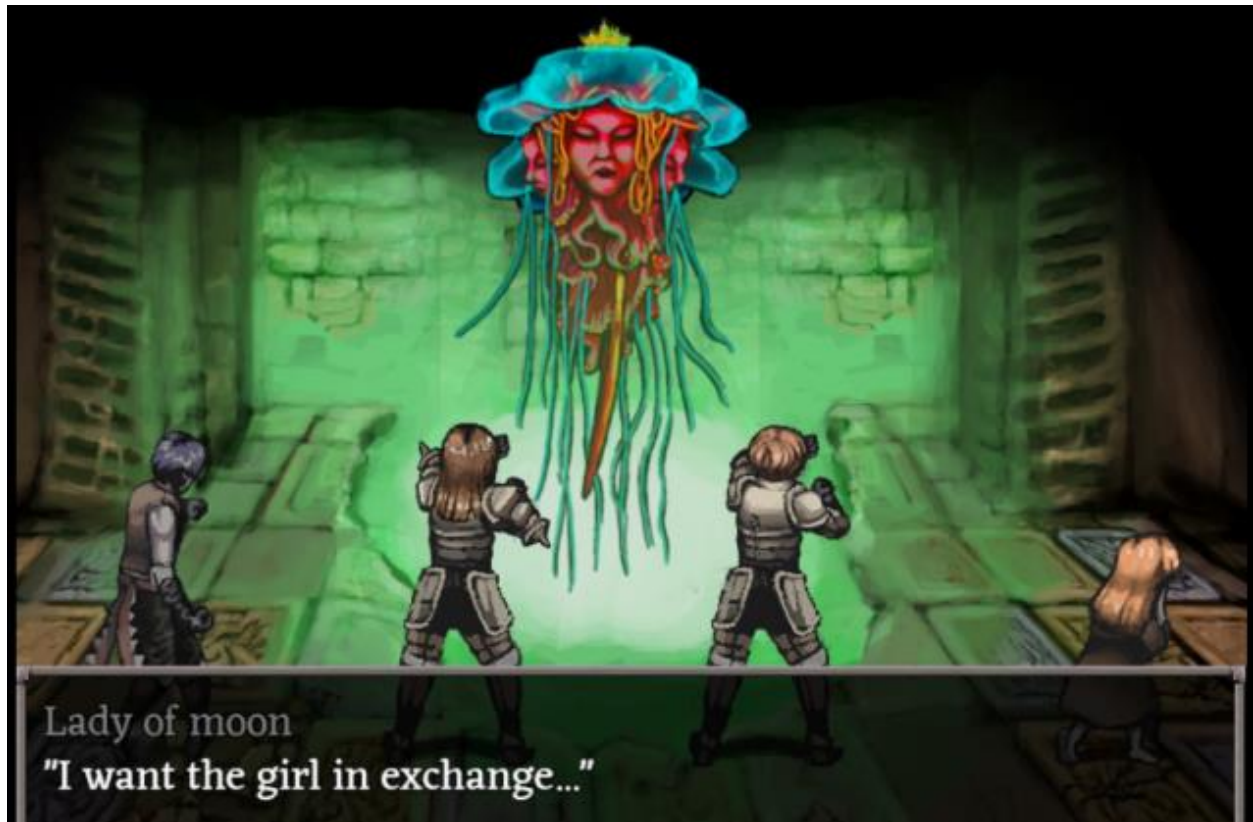
Finally, in **Reanimal**, the player plays as two brothers trying to rescue their friends. In this process, as in the **Little Nightmares saga**, they will pass through hostile environments and areas with enemies that will try to trap the protagonists. And, in this case, it serves as inspiration in the same way as the previous example with a little extra. In this game, the inspiration comes from how, if you surround yourself with good and loyal friends, you can walk through hell if necessary. As the saying goes: *‘Don't eat with people you wouldn't starve with’*.



In Reanimal, both brothers face a harsh world to save their friends.

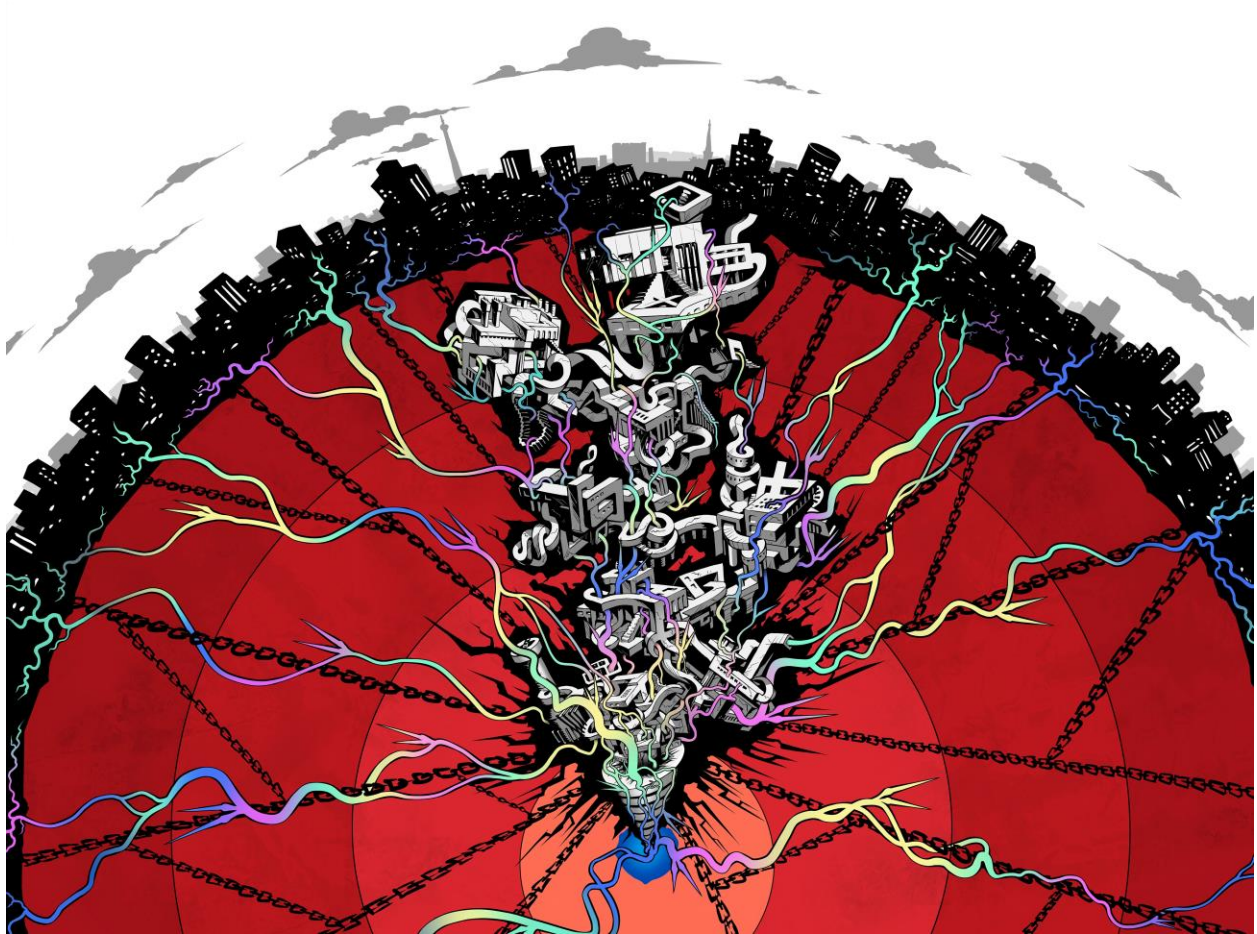
Gameplay

In order to develop the gameplay, we decided to take inspiration from games in the same genre or that share similar mechanics to *Through Their Eyes*. The first of these examples is **Fear & Hunger**, from whose gameplay we decided to take inspiration from how the characters interact with each other. In **Fear & Hunger**, the decisions the player makes directly affect their characters. For example, the player can be put in the position of sacrificing a companion and something happens in the game. It is these types of decisions that *Through Their Eyes* seeks to implement. Again, reinforcing the narrative through gameplay with moral decisions.



Fear & Hunger puts the player in front of moral decisions.

This was followed by investigating how procedural maps are often used and how rooms and corridors are laid out in them. The **Persona** series is a great example of this, especially **Persona 5** with the mementos. In **Persona 5**, the Shibuya underground becomes a labyrinthine area where the player has a completely different experience on each floor. This is because it is procedurally generated, each level and each time it is visited, they are completely different. Through Their Eyes, draws on this idea, creating a labyrinthine feeling within the school that you will visit on each level. In addition, it was decided that it was a good idea that, depending on your character's stats, you could access character dialogues or not and inform the player of the necessary requirements. This would also help with the development of the plot and narrative, adapting to the gameplay and giving it prominence and strength.



Persona 5 mementos change each time the player enters.

To make the combat more interesting and challenging, numerous references to turn-based games were sought, but the most convincing one was **Octopath Traveler**. In this game, the order of the characters turns is based on initiative. This means that whoever has the most initiative goes first and so on in succession. And its system for marking the order of the characters was also added. This information enriches the gameplay and strategy, since by informing the turn order, the player can anticipate and strategize according to the possible succession of events in the future of the combat.



The interface of Octopath Traveler portrays clearly about the current turn and the next one.

For the character selection part, there was inspiration from **The Binding of Isaac**. This game, prior to entering the level, allows the player to choose the character they wish to play. It also provides the player with information on the character's stats and different endings. Through Their Eyes, opts for a selection of personalities of the protagonist which, like The Binding of Isaac, offers different stats and endings. The difference is that this is due to the fact that the stats do not only influence the combat, but also the narrative through interacting with the different NPCs.

In addition, from **The Binding of Isaac**, the item system was taken as a reference. Through Their Eyes, it categorizes items by consumable, active and passive. Giving the player a much richer and more diverse variety of options.



In The Binding of Isaac, the game shows the player the character stats and multiple endings.

And finally, **Disco Elysium** is once again present on a narrative level, given that in the gameplay, for everything mentioned in the previous point, it influences the player to decide the path he wants to follow and the story he wants to live. The character will become the person that each player decides. This leads to the next point, the creation of multiple endings. As in many Narrative Adventure games, the addition of having multiple endings helps to enrich how the player perceives the gameplay and that they have the power in how they want to live their adventure.

Aesthetic

The aesthetic and visual points are one of the most important to support everything mentioned in the previous two points. Creating a good visual development is fundamental for the player to feel everything that has been designed at a narrative and gameplay level in a game that was born from Narrative Adventure and Roguelike game mechanics. For this point, inspiration was taken from **Reanimal**, **Happy Game** and the **Little Nightmares** saga.

In **Reanimal** and the **Little Nightmares** saga, the games are based on a child surrounded by dangerous and chaotic situations. All of them convey a sense of claustrophobia, discomfort,

helplessness and danger. The aim is for the player to put himself in the protagonist's situation and not want to live this situation in his own skin. The player is constantly seeking a safe place to rest and calm down while playing these games. And that, on seeing all this, the player learns that, despite adversity, it is always possible to get ahead.

The key to *Through Their Eyes*, is to mix the visual aspect of **Reanimal** and **Little Nightmares** together with the grotesque and unpleasant feel of **Happy Game**. In **Happy Game**, the player is continuously surrounded by unimaginable and deformed beings that, at times, put the protagonist's life at risk. In addition to this, it is not only these creatures but also objects in the environment that can kill the protagonist. And, in this aspect, it is this mixture that *Through Their Eyes* wants to develop. An environment and beings that the protagonist fears and does not want to face under any circumstances.



Happy Game creates the perfect experience to feel uncomfortable.

And to unify all the previous points and to be able to make the most of the narrative, we use the method that **Inscryption** has in transmitting the story visually through the environment and the gameplay. This game is a specialist in transmitting in a subtle way small clues for the player to join the whole story from beginning to end, as well as extra things that are not revealed directly, but just through this method.



Inscryption foreshadows game items and objects constantly through the whole game.

Art Guide - Visual References

For the visual references and artwork of the video game, the references that inspired Through Their Eyes have been: **Reanimal**, the **Little Nightmares saga** and **Persona 5**.

In the case of **Reanimal** and the **Little Nightmares saga**, they are taken as examples to describe the visual style sought. A 2.5D game with isometric perspective, grotesque and simple art, with a setting that evokes feelings of discomfort, claustrophobia and a sense of helplessness. These games also have a dark art visual style, mixed with enemies with much more detail than the surrounding environment. It is precisely this mixture that makes the enemies more prominent in the scene and makes it impossible not to look at them and feel your stomach churn.



Little Nightmares dark art is represented during the whole gameplay.

From **Persona 5**, they take as an example the look of the mementos, the atmosphere is abstract and surreal. This is achieved by using real locations, distorting them by twisting walls, placing objects out of place. In this way, the game manages to provoke a sense of escape in the player. The environment incites feelings of being out of place and of exploring to find the exit as quickly as possible, where the world itself provokes a sensation like the phenomenon of ‘Uncanny Valley’. The human being sees something similar to real life, but these distortions generate an unconscious rejection in the person and generate an internal discomfort.



In Persona 5, mementos are inspired in Shibuya's metro station and are deformed and twisted.

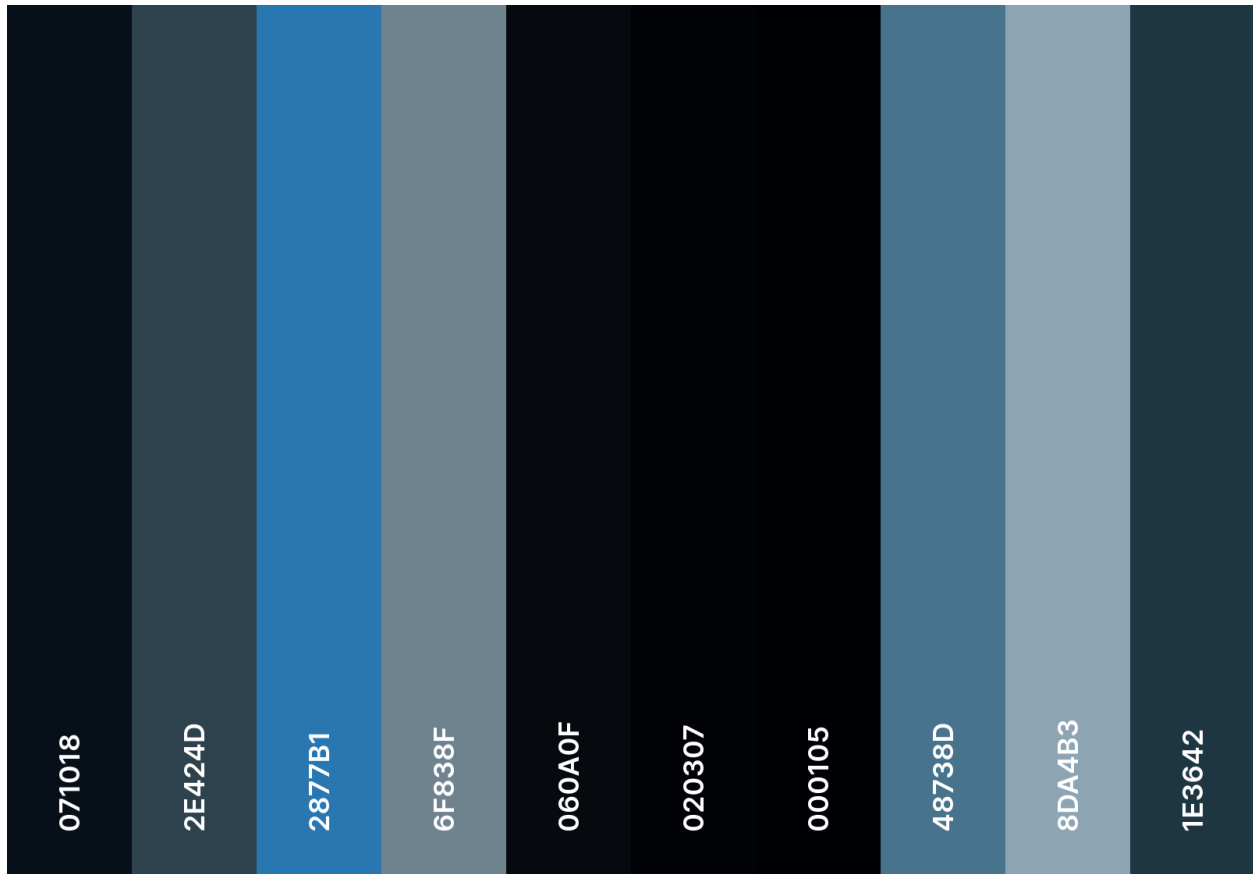
The characters style is for them to look simple and relatable, emphasizing the protagonist's youth and vulnerability. Like it is done in the references used for the art style. On the other hand, the enemies must look grotesque, exaggerated monsters reflecting the protagonists' fears.

For each location of the game, there has to be different color palettes. Each zone represents different emotions and sensations that the main character feels inside them. Here is the list of the locations and the color palette for each of them.

- **Endless Corridors:** They convey the feeling that the school is alive. To achieve this, shades of red will be used, as if representing the intestine of a living being.



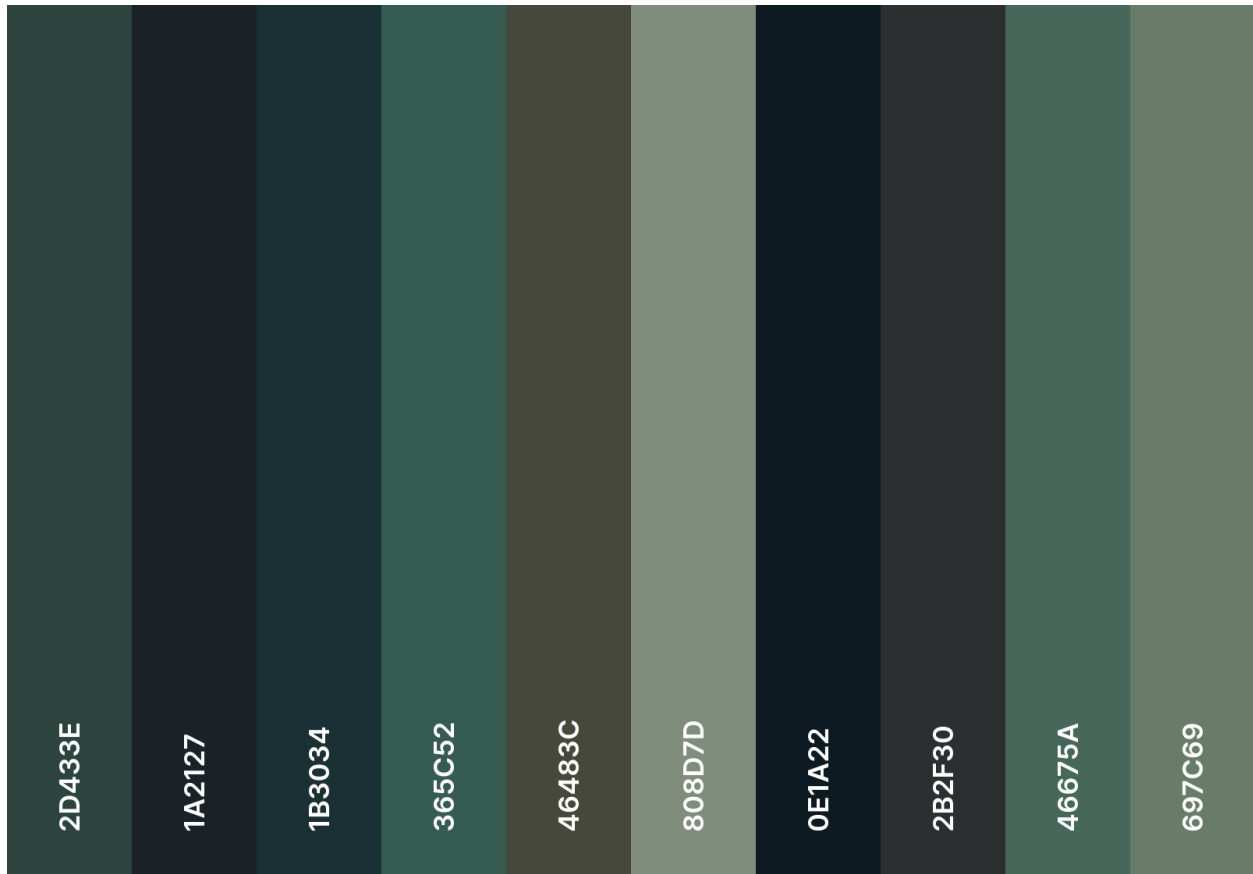
- **Science Lab:** As it is a laboratory, it should have a bluish color palette. That gives the sensation of a cold and distant place, where experiments are carried out, some with living beings.



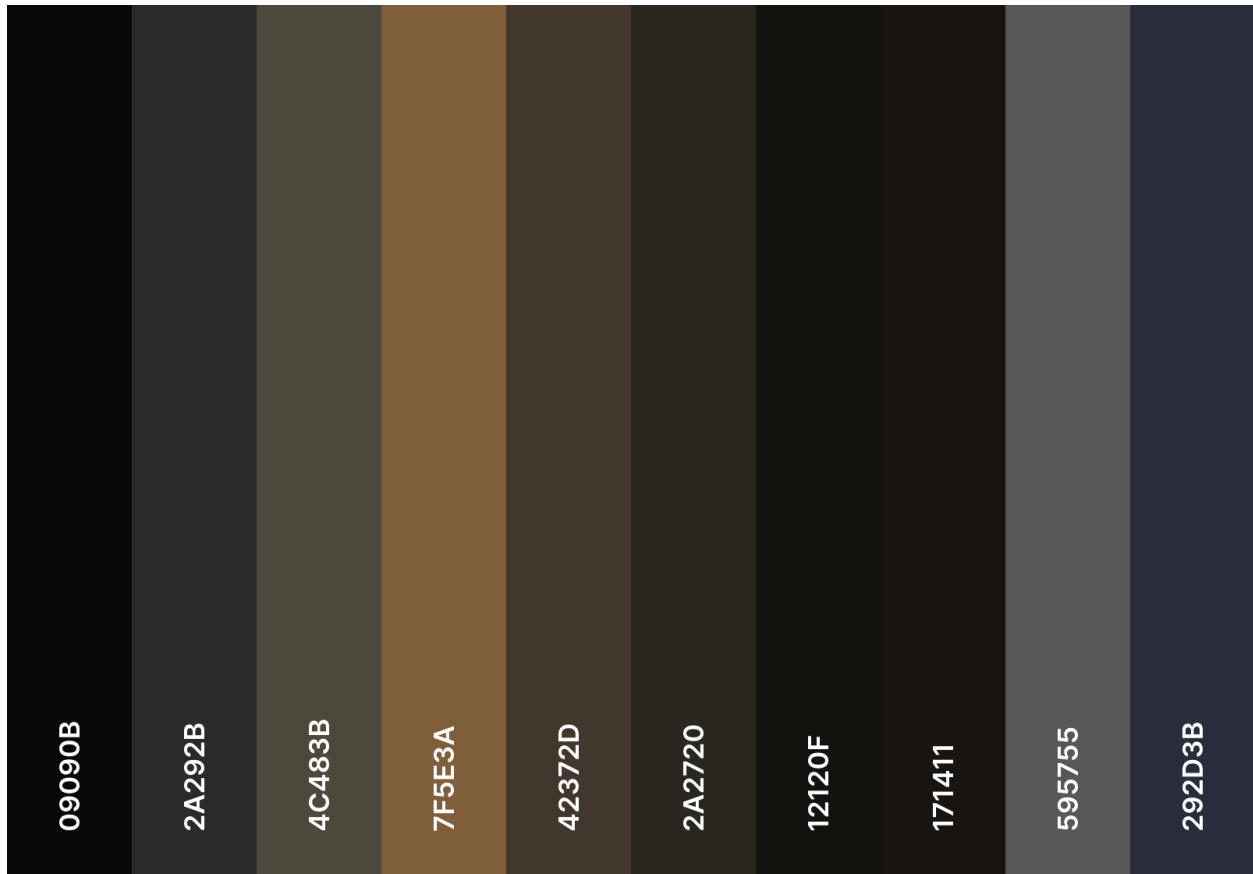
- **Library:** Libraries are places surrounded by brown shades of wood and yellow pages of books. They are also places with a lot of amplitude and that provoke a sensation of distance. Likewise, in the game it is a hostile place, and as such should be reflected in the choice of colors.



- **Bathroom:** At Through Their Eyes, the **Bathrooms** are colored green like in daycare centers. This tone avoids the feeling of cleanliness and purity that it should have. Instead, it is a bile shade mixed with toxic yellow. The mixture of these colors creates the idea that it looks like a very unsafe place and can provoke states in the characters. This is because it signals the connection it has to the sewers.



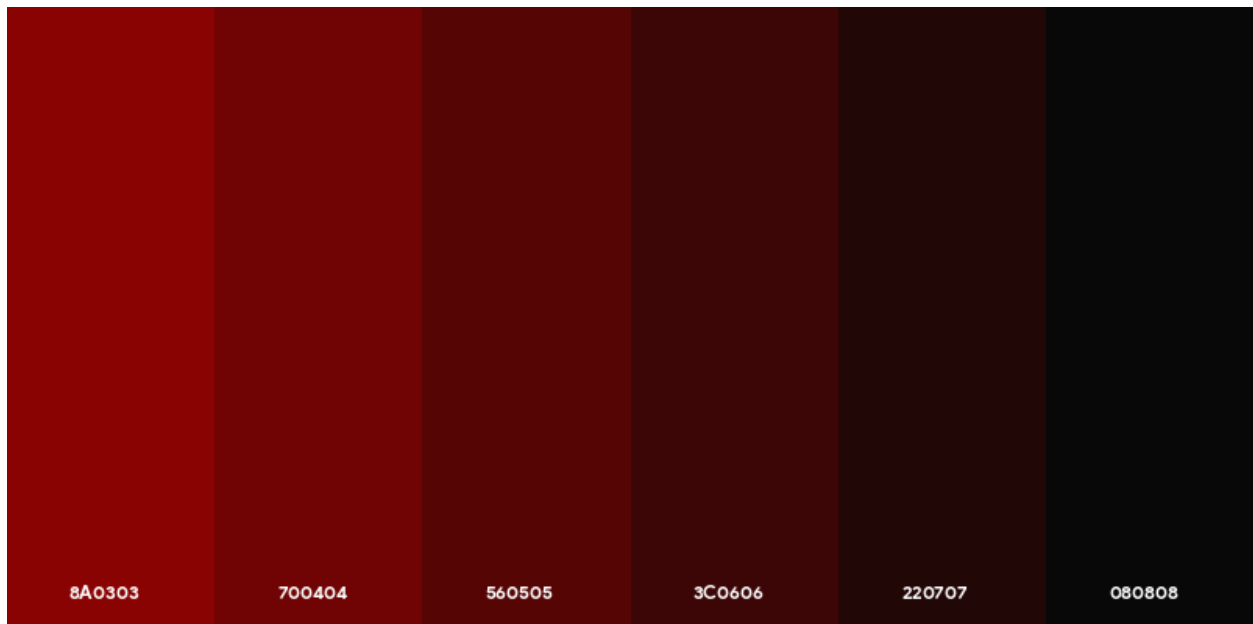
- **Sewers:** A desolate place, full of mold, humidity and excrement. This color palette evokes the feeling of not even wanting to step on the ground, of wanting to run away and quickly pass the location.



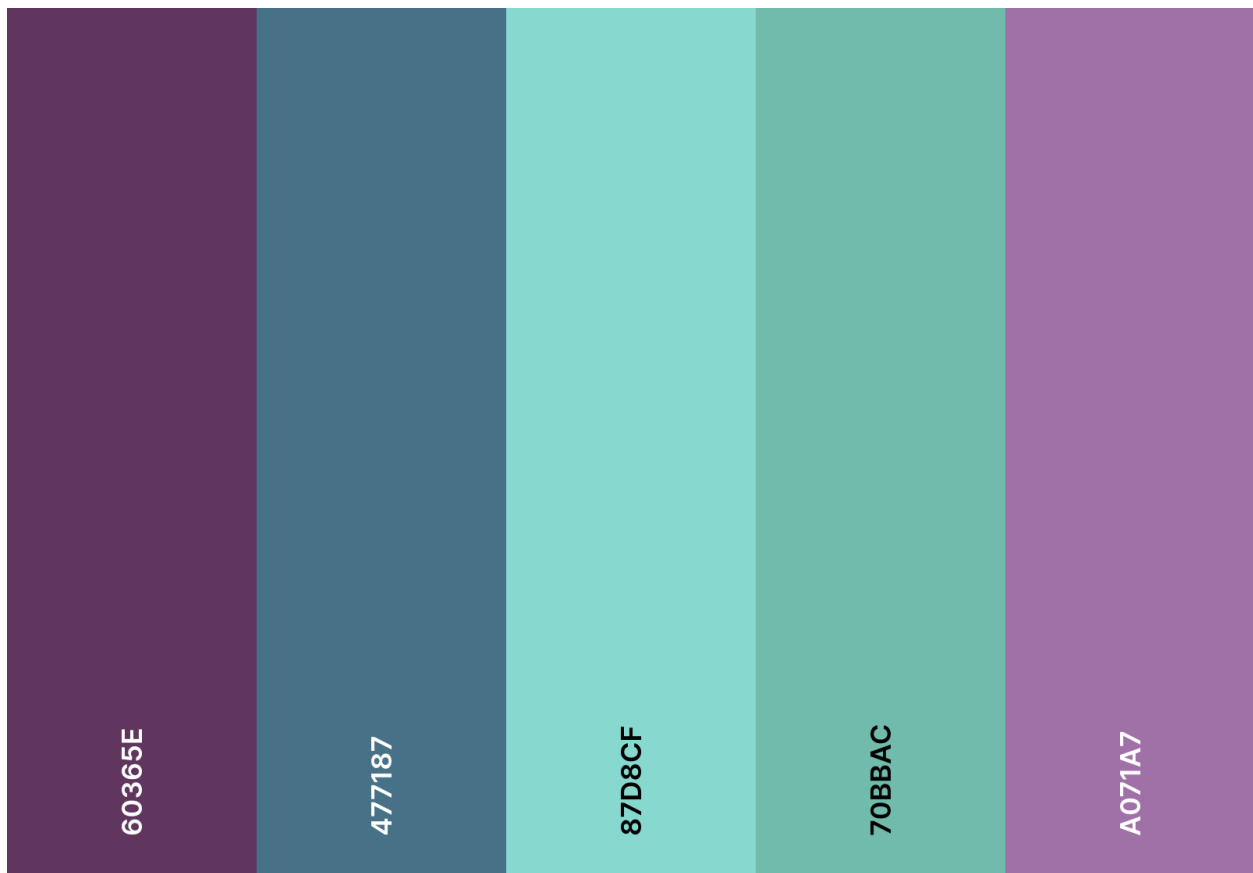
- **Olivier's Room:** A color palette mixing blue and blood red tones are essential for **Olivier's room**. The blue tones present a melancholic and sad tone, like the end that this character suffers. And the reddish tones represent Oliver's decision to end his life, and all the anger he has inside against the rest of the children.



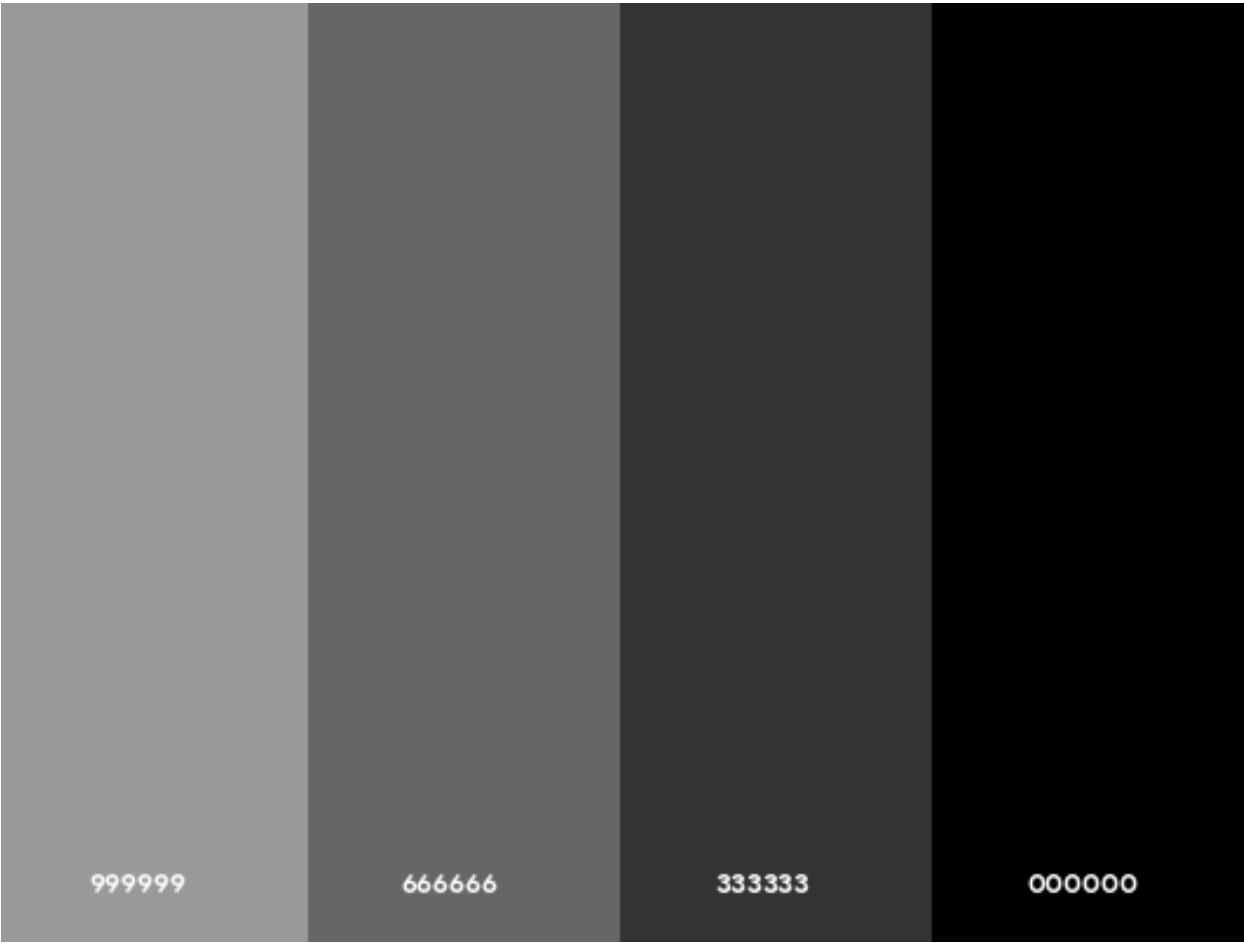
- **Labyrinth:** The **Labyrinth** is the equivalent of the **Endless Corridors** but with darker shades of red. It should represent the feeling that the player is at a much lower level, where the light cannot reflect and the only thing that remains is that which observes from the shadows.



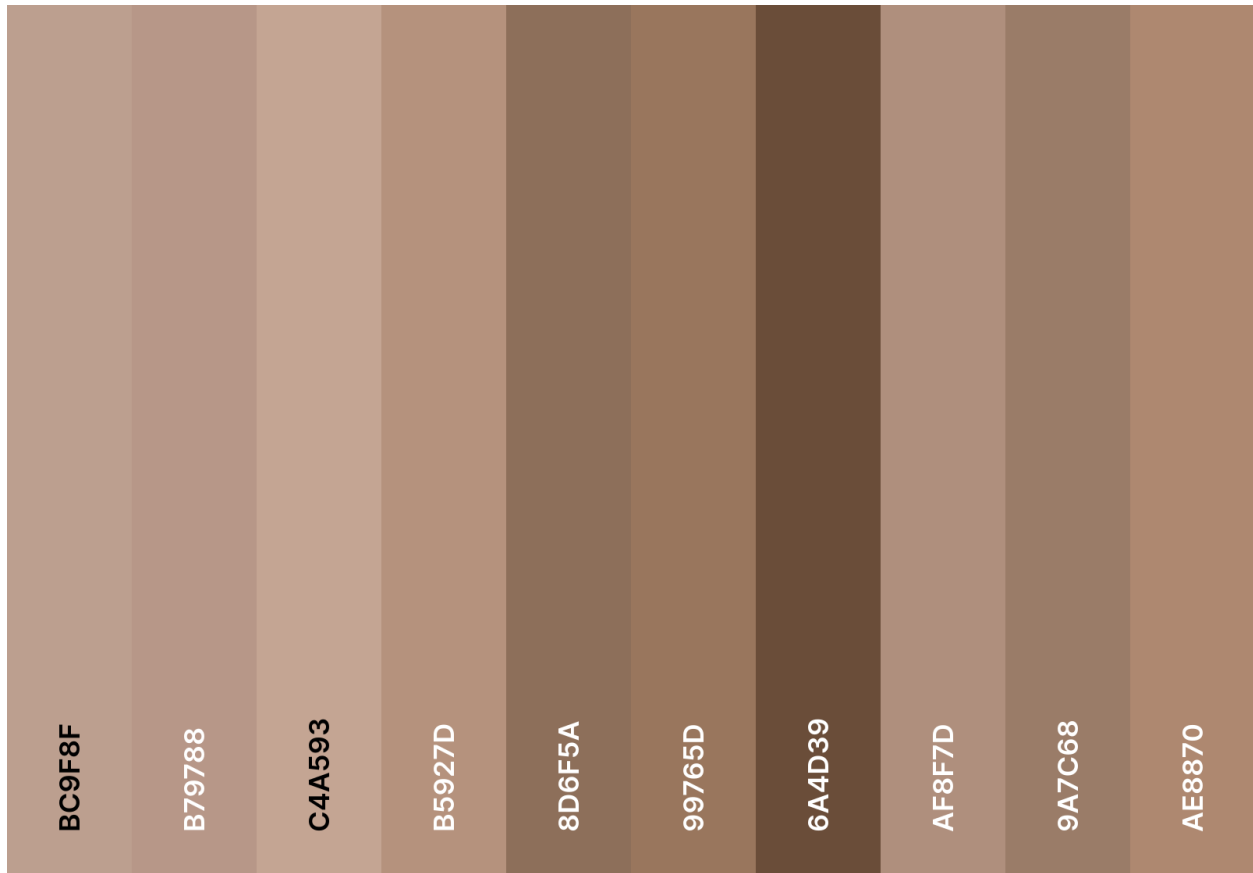
- **The Abyss:** Full color palette of blood red, going darker the deeper it goes.



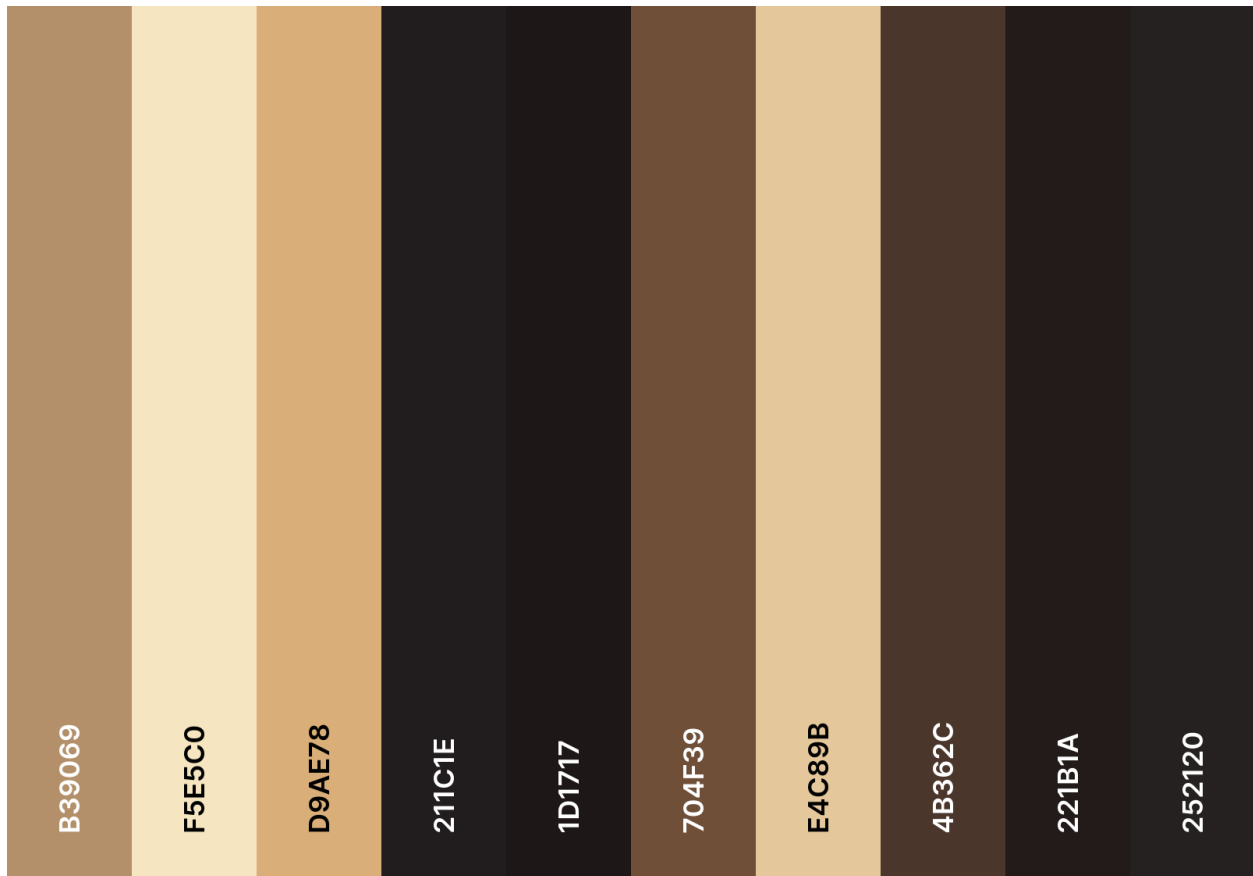
- **Playground:** The outside world, hostile and merciless. The color palette represents disinterest, something that attracts little attention compared to the rest of the school.



- **Gym:** The bullies' den. A mud brown palette is used to represent the dirtiness and stinkiness that the main character feels towards them.

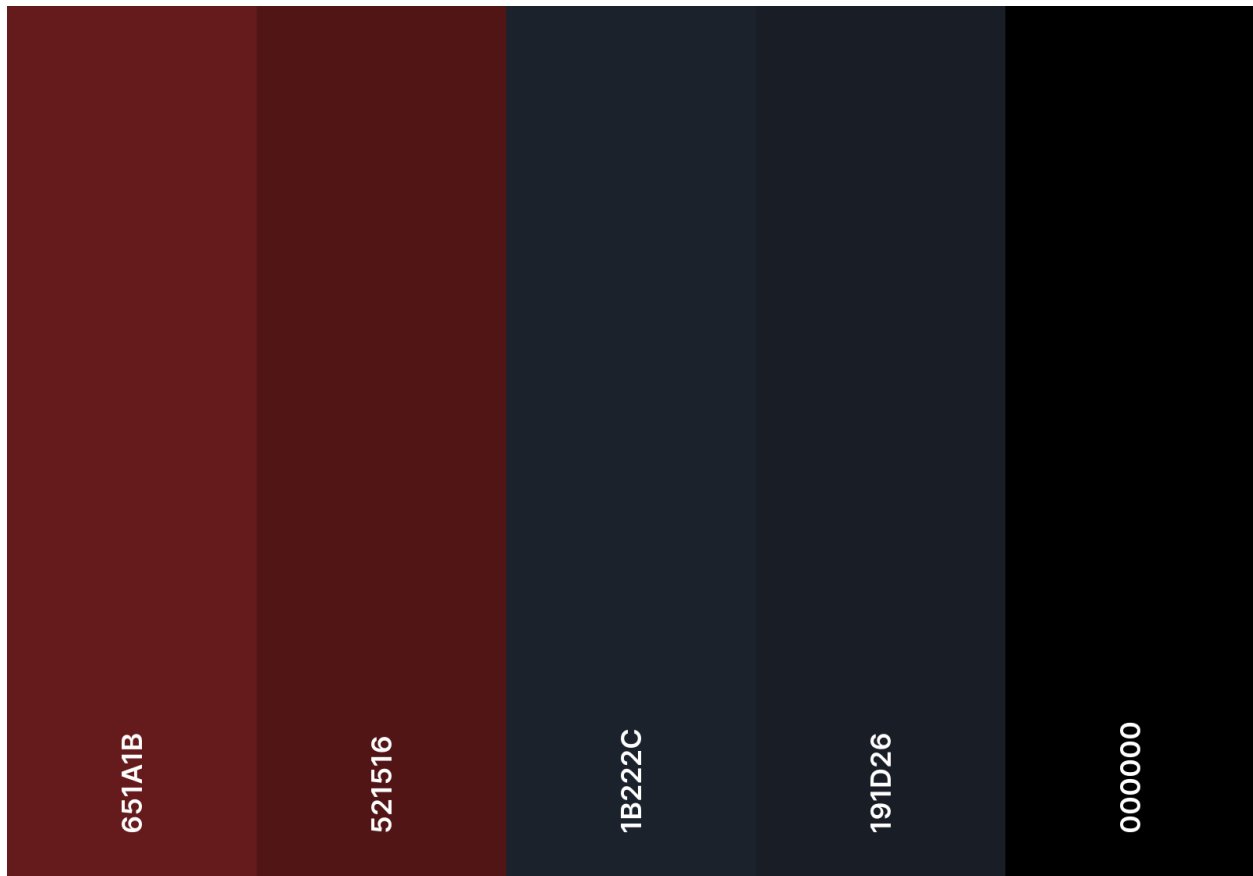


- **Shadow Theatre:** Completely dark, with a spotlight following the player. The only illuminated part is the stage. Waiting for the final dance of the player and his biggest enemy. A simple and soft palette.

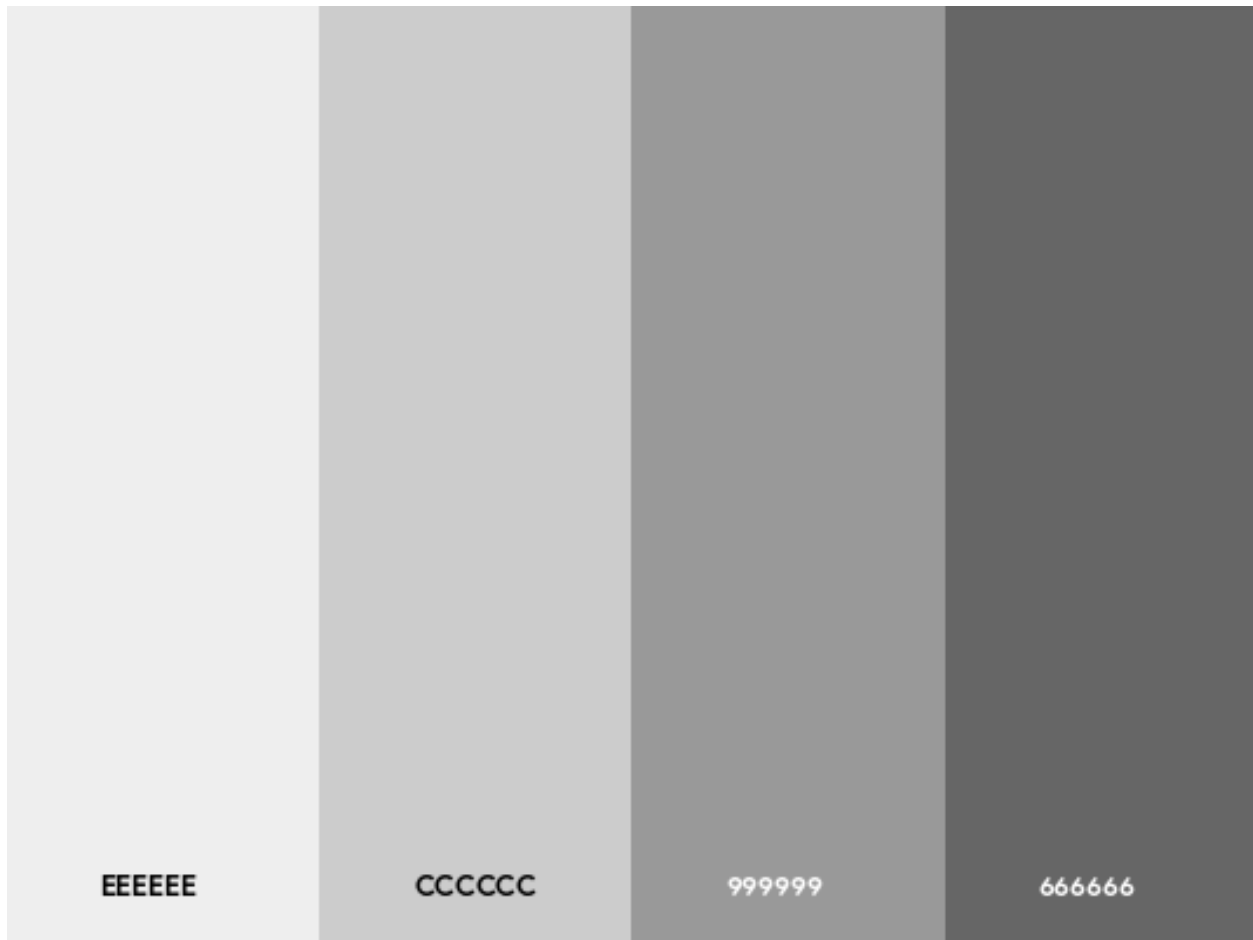


- **Night School:** Same as during the day, with the difference that during the night the light is much dimmer. Only a little circle around the player is illuminated unless an external object casts light.

- **Headmaster's Office:** This location is represented with color tones that incite the supernatural. Evoking sensations of being in a parallel world outside of the human one, outside of what is known, outside of what is comfortable. The protagonist is unwelcome.



- **Rooftop:** As in the **Playground**, but with brighter tones and surrounded by a dark mist that hides the background for the player.



Key Mechanics

Turn-based combat

In which the player alternates turn with his enemies during combat. This will be centered on the **initiative** of the characters, in which the character with the highest **initiative** will take the first turn and so on in descending order to the character with the lowest **initiative**.

Interactions with NPC's

Interactions with NPCs will develop the story in different ways. They will add extra quests to the player, give more depth to the game's story and in some specific cases, they can become companions or enemies of the protagonist depending on how they interact with them. In addition, depending on which characters are in the player's party, some NPCs may become enemies due to feuds with other NPCs.

Choosing a path

Since the main idea is to give the player a sensation of complete **agency**, it is entirely up to the player which story to follow. Because there are numerous paths within each level, this will influence the story and the gameplay that the player experiences. This is focused on nurturing the gameplay experience through the narrative, without losing the **dynamism** that the game seeks to give.

Stats and Items

Throughout each level, the player will be able to modify their character's stats in a stat tree, as well as find items to interact with the environment, receive buffs or remove debuffs. In addition, external to the gameplay, there will be a character selection.

- **Character selection**

Prior to entering a level, the player will be able to choose the character that they are going to play as. This implies a change of stats and, consequently, a change of **personality** that will influence the narrative aspect such as which NPCs the player can get to join the adventure.

- **Stat Tree**

During the development of the level, the player will be able to modify the statistics of his characters through a statistics tree. This stat tree is divided into 4 sections:

- **Resilience**, this statistic will modify the values so that the protagonist can withstand more damage received, with stats for life, **physical** resistance and **stress** resistance.
- **Psyche**, this stat will modify the values so that the protagonist can deal higher **stress** damage to enemies.
- **Strength**, this stat will modify the values so that the protagonist can deal more **physical** damage to enemies.
- **Intelligence**, this statistic will modify the values for the protagonist to decide if he tends to support the team with **health** and **status healing** and buffs, or if he tends to be a control character with **area damage**, **status infliction** and **debuffs** on enemies.

Core Loop

Start a New Run

1. Select Character
2. Choose Difficulty Settings

Progress Through the Narrative

1. Interact with characters and NPCs
2. Explore different story routes and areas

Face Your Fears

1. Reach the end of a chosen route
2. Manage stress and avoid succumbing to it (failure conditions)

Return to Main Menu

1. Navigate through the menu or Start a New Run.

Gameplay

Game Structure

- **Procedural Generation:** The game world, enemies, and items are procedurally generated at the start of each run. This ensures a fresh and unique experience each time.
- **Dynamic Narrative:** The narrative evolves based on the player's actions, choices, and interactions with NPCs. Key decisions lead to branching story paths, affecting gameplay and unlocking new content.
- **Exploration & Progression:** Players explore randomized rooms with the potential to unlock fixed story rooms essential for the narrative's progression. New characters, items, and abilities are unlocked as the player progresses.

Exploration and Progression

Through Their Eyes, uses **procedural** maps. This means that each game features procedurally generated maps, ensuring variety and replayability. Key locations (e.g., infirmaries, libraries) have a fixed chance of appearing as the story unfolds.

NPC Progression

To progress the storylines of each of the NPCs, the player must interact with them. This means that, if the player doesn't interact with them, they remain the same until the dialogue is started. After this happens, the level of trust the NPC has with the player is built through completing specific quests and making decisions that align with NPCs' goals and convictions.

Example: Helping an NPC defeat a boss might unlock new abilities or narrative routes.

Fixed and Randomized Rooms

To ensure that the procedural levels work, there's two types of rooms in Through Their Eyes:

- **Fixed Story Rooms:** Critical locations that do not change between runs but are vital for advancing the main story. This room's content doesn't change, but its location on the map will.
- **Randomized Rooms:** Exploration-driven rooms that are randomly generated each time, providing unique challenges and rewards.

Skills and Stats System

Instead of traditional leveling up, characters improve stats (**Strength, Psyche, Resilience, and Intellect**) by taking specific actions and acquiring items. In Through Their Eyes, this system is called "**Stat Growth**". This system develops as players advance; allowing them to choose new skills related to their stats.

- **Skill Rarity:** Skills come in different rarities, the higher the stat level, the higher the odds of encountering a higher rarity skill are.
- **Upgradable Skills:** Some skills can be further upgraded via items or interactions with NPCs.
- **NPC Skills:** NPCs also develop their own abilities based on their individual stats and progress in their storylines. These are not upgraded by the player, but by their own progression system.

- **Character Stats:**
 - **Strength:** Allows the characters to perform **physical** attacks and abilities in combat.
 - **Psyche:** Acts as the character's mana, determining the number and power of skills they can use. Focuses on psychological attacks dealing **stress** damage. Can inflict **Primary** states.
 - **Resilience:** Acts as the resistances of the character, blocking a percentage of the damage received increasing with the stat level. It also provides support against status effects.
 - **Intellect:** Improves strategic skills, buffs, debuffs, and analysis abilities, influencing magical or support-based actions. Can inflict **Secondary** states.

Item System

Items are categorized into three types, which can significantly affect gameplay.

- **Active Items:** Players can carry only one active item. These items can often be used inside and outside combat. They provide unique abilities and stats to the player. Some may also be needed to unlock certain routes.
Example: **'Lantern'** lights up the room in front of him in the form of a cone. Also reduces enemy fear effects and reveals hidden areas.
- **Passive Items:** Players can equip up to 12 passive items. These items provide stat upgrades and upgrades to the player.
Example: **'School Map'** reveals special rooms on the minimap.
Example: **'Photo of Younger Brother'** increases Resilience when Sam is in the party.
- **Consumable Items:** Used once, these items are vital for combat and exploration.
Example: **'Healing Potion'** restores physical health.
Example: **'Dynamite'** can deal high damage to enemies or open paths (opens the sewer routes).

Combat System

Since *Through Their Eyes* has a turn-based combat system, it's influenced by each character's stats, abilities, and equipped items. For this to work smoothly and add more depth to the gameplay, the **Initiative System** was created. **Initiative** determines the order of actions that will take place during combat. Each character's turn is represented on a timeline, with certain actions affecting turn order. For this system to work, certain interactions and conditions have been considered such as the following:

- **Surprise Attacks:** As in **Ruined King**, you can hit enemies outside combat, giving you the opportunity to ambush enemies. If the player ambushes an enemy, they act first. Conversely, if the player is ambushed, enemies start the fight.
- **Status Effects:** Certain abilities and states can change the turn order and can alter how combat plays out by delaying actions or restricting abilities.
- **Actions per Turn:** Each character takes one action per turn, with exceptions for powerful enemies and bosses who may act multiple times.
- **Maximum Team Size:** A player can have up to three active characters in combat at a time (main character and two allies).

Status Effects

To fully understand how combat works, how status effects work must be understood. There are two types of status effects **Primary** and **Secondary** status effects. A character can be afflicted by 1 status effect of each category at a time.

- **Primary**

These stats are consequences of **stress** damage. Some **Primary** status effects can evolve if left untreated. And reduce your stats both in and out of combat. Here is a list of some types of **Primary** status effects.

- **Fear:** The character is paralyzed with terror, affecting his ability to act clearly.
Effects:
 - Increases the time needed for the character to act. If it's activated during the turn, it delays the turn of the character.
 - There is a 25%-50% chance that he will not perform any action.
 - Reduces combat accuracy by 20%-40%.
 - If not dealt with it can lead to **Despair**.
- **Despair:** The character loses hope, which decreases his ability to resist enemy attacks.
Effects:
 - Reduces the effectiveness of defensive or healing abilities by 30%.
 - Nearby allies may enter **Hysteria** if they see the character in this state spreading to nearby allies.
 - It lasts until the state is cured.
- **Hysteria:** The character enters a state of extreme emotion, making him unpredictable but powerful.
Effects:
 - Doubling of damage inflicted, but also increases damage received by 50%.
 - Cannot defend or use defensive abilities.
 - If the state lasts, it evolves to **Panic**.

- **Panic:** The character enters a state of extreme anxiety, acting unpredictably.

Effects:

- The character acts immediately in combat and takes a random action.
- If the character attacks, the target can be a random ally or enemy.
- Reduces the effectiveness of consumable items used by the character by 50% for the duration of the state.

- **Reluctance:** The character loses motivation.

Effects:

- Reduces initiative if you were out of combat.
- Reduces movement speed by 25%.
- If left untreated it can evolve into **Apathy**.

- **Apathy:** The character loses interest in the fight, acting mechanically and without motivation.

Effects:

- Reduces action speed and damage inflicted by 30%-50%.
- The character cannot receive benefits from skills that increase stats or heal health.
- Reduces movement speed by 25%.

- **Secondary**

These stats are consequences of **physical** damage. Some **Secondary** status effects can evolve if left untreated. And reduce your stats both in and out of combat. Here is a list of some types of Secondary status effects.

- **Bleeding:** The character suffers open wounds that weaken him over time.

Effects:

- Loses a fixed percentage of maximum health at the start of each turn or every few seconds out of combat.
- The effect can accumulate with multiple instances of **Bleeding**.

- **Poisoned:** A toxic substance affects the character's body, gradually weakening it.
Effects:
 - Reduces health by a progressively higher percentage for 3-5 turns.
 - Decreases stats related to **Resilience** and **Psyche** for the duration of the effect.
 - Some enemies can exploit this state to inflict additional damage.
- **Stunned:** A mental blow or hit leaves the character temporarily incapacitated.
Effects:
 - The character loses the next turn.
 - This state is automatically removed after one turn.
- **Exhaustion:** The character suffers physical or mental exhaustion, reducing his overall capacity.
Effects:
 - Reduces damage to **Psyche** and **Intelligence** skills by 10%-15%.
 - Increases **Psyche** skill cost.
 - May persist until the character rests or uses a regenerating item.
- **Weakened:** The character is in a general state of frailty.
Effects:
 - Inflicts 20% less damage on **physical** attacks and **physical** abilities.
 - May persist until the character rests or uses a regenerating item.
- **Marked:** An enemy marks the character as its main target, increasing its vulnerability.
Effects:
 - The character takes 20%-30% more damage from certain enemies or attack types.
 - Increases the probability of being attacked.

Desired Gameplay Experience

Combat Challenge

To offer a challenge to the players, combat requires strategic decisions about the use of skills, status management and choice of enemies to face. The player must learn to **manage** not only his health, but also his mental stamina and character skills. This includes a turn-based system that emphasizes the importance of each action, making the player value his decisions in each combat. Through Their Eyes, challenges player using strategy and resource management.

To implement the feeling of progression of **difficulty**, as the player progresses, enemies become more complex. Introducing new mechanics, abilities and combinations of status effects that force the player to adapt and evolve their strategies. Combat offers a progressive but fair challenge, where each defeat is seen as an opportunity to learn and improve.

Narrative Immersion

In Through Their Eyes, players feel a connection with the characters, both playable and NPCs. Decisions made have an emotional impact, influencing both the state of the characters and the course of the story. Interactions are rich in content, offering not only dialogue, but also **opportunities** for developing relationships with NPCs. This is achieved through a system of decisions that have a direct impact on the player's equipment, story and relationships with NPCs.

Since players decisions carry consequences both in narrative and gameplay. These decisions open new paths or close others, affecting both the player's immediate future and the final outcome of the game. This reinforces the idea that every choice matters, and the player must assume the consequences of the actions.

Exploration and Discovery

Given the use of procedural generation, each game offers a unique experience. Replayability and variety are achieved through narrative paths, enemies and items that change from game to game, which encourages exploration and the desire to discover new things. Players are motivated to play multiple times to explore all the possibilities of the game.

The player feels satisfaction and curiosity in discovering new objects, abilities, and secrets; reinforcing this sensation of rewards through discovery. This includes the inclusion of secret rooms or events, as well as unlocking characters and abilities that expand the playable options.

Balance between Risk and Reward

As the player progresses, the stresses of the game are felt, both in combat and in the narrative. Status effects such as **Stress** and **Hysteria** challenge the stability of the characters, creating high-risk situations. However, the player also feels a constant sense of reward when overcoming these challenges. Forcing players to manage the risks taken.

Rewards are meaningful and feel like an accomplishment. They can include skill upgrades, unlocking new narrative paths, or even unlocking additional characters. The sense of progress is present, both in terms of skills and story progression. Giving satisfying rewards is key in *Through Their Eyes* to promote exploration and investigation to players.

In addition to items and skills, narrative progress also offers rewards. These can be additional content unlocks, cutscenes and events that deepen the story of the world and characters. The player feels that their decisions and progress contribute significantly to the plot. Since *Through Their Eyes* is a narrative driven game, giving narrative rewards is key to the success of the game.

Narrative

The story revolves around an unnamed protagonist who represents a deep and complex internal struggle against the fears of a child, as seen through his own eyes.

Set in a bleak school replete with symbolism, the narrative explores themes of self-forgiveness, personal acceptance, resentment and the balance between rebellion and responsibility. Leading to a list of different narrative themes that players may explore in each level.

The importance of human connections

The narrative emphasizes that life's darkest challenges are easier to overcome when you rely on others. Allying with peers will not only make battles more manageable but will also unlock unique parts of your stories.

The dilemma of solitude

The player can also choose to face danger alone. While this might grant darker endings, it reflects the emotional isolation and internal struggle of someone who rejects the support of others, bearing the full weight of the world in complete solitude.

In Search of Identity

Some of the player's decisions will put the protagonist in doubt about who he really is. As you progress, these emotions are directly confronted, challenging the player to accept or reject them. This is also reflected in the multiple personalities available in the character selection, which will be unlocked as the main character doubts himself.

Redemption or damnation

The end of the game will depend on how you relate to your allies, your decisions in key scenarios, and whether you choose to sacrifice yourself or others. This central message revolves around how acts of compassion or selfishness define your path.

Get to Know Yourself

Through the game, the player will be able to unlock the different personalities of the protagonist. A hint for the player will be the character selection, that will portray all personalities unlocked and locked.

- **Base Personality.** The first unlocked personality.
 - Ability: Balanced in stats.
 - Stats:
 - Resilience - 2
 - Psyche - 2
 - Strength - 2
 - Intelligence - 2
- **True Self.** Facing one's demons reveals a new personality, free from the chains of people pleasing.
 - Ability: Lifesteals when dealing physical damage.
 - Stats:
 - Resilience - 4
 - Psyche - 1
 - Strength - 5
 - Intelligence - 2
- **Penitent.** Burdened by the guilt of his actions, he is continually punished for the rest of his life.
 - Ability: Immune to states.
 - Stats:
 - Resilience - 5
 - Psyche - 1
 - Strength - 4
 - Intelligence - 2

- **The Imaginary Friend.** Even though there's no friends left, this personality carries them in his heart, or in his head.
 - Ability: Has a copy of himself with opposite stats.
 - Stats:
 - Resilience - 5
 - Psyche - 1
 - Strength - 5
 - Intelligence - 1
- **Fulfilled.** Helping his friends has filled him full of love. Now that life has a meaning, everything gives you strength to carry on.
 - Ability: Has the ability to heal and inflict Secondary states.
 - Stats:
 - Resilience - 4
 - Psyche - 2
 - Strength - 1
 - Intelligence - 5
- **Freed.** This is the normal personality of the main character after overcoming his fears.
 - Ability: Boosted balanced stats.
 - Stats:
 - Resilience - 3
 - Psyche - 3
 - Strength - 3
 - Intelligence - 3
- **Possessed.** The personality that has been possessed by his imagination and fears. Completely lost.
 - Ability: Inflicts Primary states to the enemies.
 - Stats:
 - Resilience - 4
 - Psyche - 5
 - Strength - 1
 - Intelligence - 2

- **Resilient.** The Abyss has been the toughest journey of the protagonist. Now there's nothing in the world able to stop him.
 - Ability: Receives half of the damage because of his tough skin. Is also able to apply healing to himself.
 - Stats:
 - Resilience - 5
 - Psyche - 1
 - Strength - 2
 - Intelligence - 4
- **The Hidden One.** The hours spent in hiding have given this personality the ability to walk like mist, unnoticed.
 - Ability: During the night, deals double damage to enemies.
 - Stats:
 - Resilience - 2
 - Psyche - 4
 - Strength - 5
 - Intelligence - 1
- **Rampaged.** Fury and excitement are everything left for this personality. The fire burning his veins calls him to keep pursuing justice and fight.
 - Ability: The lower the health, the more damage it deals. The last physical wound that would inflict a Secondary state, would be skipped because of his driven motivation to fight.
 - Stats:
 - Resilience - 5
 - Psyche - 1
 - Strength - 4
 - Intelligence - 2

Relationships with Allies

Each ally has a personal story and a narrative role that intertwines with the main plot. Deciding to ally with them, gives the player access to special abilities and unique dialogues but also exposes them to danger. If they fall, the player could lose parts of the narrative... and a friend.

Get to Know Your Allies

- **Sam, The Protector**

Sam is a kid that is known for being a heartwarming kid. He is that guy who cares about others and is genuinely interested in their welfare. You could even say that he sacrifices himself to make others well. This is true since he lost his older brother to bullying. Since he was very young at the time, he blames himself for not having been able to do anything to prevent it. Since then, he vowed that he would not allow injustice in his environment and fights for it every day.

- Represents self-forgiveness.
- Will get mad if you don't help NPCs in trouble.
- Due to his relentless behavior to vengeance his brother, when he's about to die he resurrects with half his **physical** and **stress** points and no states.
- Stats:
 - Resilience - 4
 - Psyche - 1
 - Strength - 5
 - Intelligence - 2

- **Olivier, The Tormented Soul**

Olivier is a former student who, like the protagonist, was asphyxiated with tremendous social anxiety. This burden was too heavy for Olivier, and he ended up ending his life with the weapon he was going to use to confront his fears. After this, Olivier became attached to the school and wanders its endless corridors scaring the people he identifies as his victims.

- Represents the desire for vengeance.
- Olivier will guide you through the depths of the labyrinth to his room.
- Olivier stands out for his **Psyche**, making him immune to status effects and specialist in infusing them.
- Stats:
 - Resilience - 1
 - Psyche - 5
 - Strength - 4
 - Intelligence - 2

- **Clara, The Crystal Maiden**

Clara is the perfect example of a normal child. She gets good enough grades, plays sports, has good manners and cares about others. But behind her façade, she hides a fear that she has repressed for as long as she has been aware of it. Clara is terrified of not being perfect, of not living up to other expectations and of not being enough for others. This leads her to look excessively at how she looks in the mirror. She is so worried that she always carries a small mirror in her handbag, so that she can look at herself in any situation. All this pressure has led her to suffer from bulimia, causing her to constantly fluctuate in her physical appearance.

- Represents self-love.
- Food items increase her maximum **physical points** increasing her size but decreasing her **Psyche**.
- Clara can enter the baths and sacrifice **physical points** to recover **Psyche** but decreasing her size.
- Performing these actions multiple times can lead to Clara's death.
- Stats:
 - Resilience - 5
 - Psyche - 1
 - Strength - 2
 - Intelligence - 4

- **Sophia, The Model Student**

Sophia is a girl who has no friends, whom no one can stand. This is because she is the headmaster's daughter. No one has been encouraged to get to know her, and she is constantly isolated. Despite having the highest grades in class, trying harder than her classmates and being the class delegate, she has the feeling that even the teachers don't want to talk to her.

But Sophia, in spite of this, is a very curious child and her high intelligence makes up for her lack of social and physical ability.

- Represents the wish for freedom.
- Excels in her **Intelligence** stats, granting her the ability to see the weaknesses of the enemies being able to inflict **Primary** and **Secondary** states.
- Stats:
 - Resilience - 2
 - Psyche - 4
 - Strength - 1
 - Intelligence - 5

- **Jimmy, The Outcast**

No information from Jimmy. Jimmy from the outside looks like a child immersed in his world. He is always seen talking to himself and playing happily. When someone talks to him, he runs away scared. No one has ever seen him without his bag covering his face.

- Represents self-confidence.
- He is very affected by what others say about him.
- When Jimmy has no states, his **Resilience** is on the maximum level, otherwise it goes to the lowest level.
- Stats:
 - Resilience – 1/5
 - Psyche - 1
 - Strength - 4
 - Intelligence - 2

- **Irene, The Rebel**

Irene has grown up in a hostile environment. With alcoholic parents, she never had stability at home and no one to bring food to the table. Even though she refused at the beginning, she had no choice but to steal food to eat.

The word of her actions spread quickly, granting her the title of Delinquent Student for the rest of her school life, so she decided to live up to their expectations.

- Represents balance between rebellion and responsibility.
- Expert in quick attacks and evasion.
- She stands out for her high **Resilience**.
- To unlock her, you must defeat her in a friendly fight on the school **Rooftop**.
- With Irene on your team, some enemies (teachers) who were not hostile to you will now be.
- Stats:
 - Resilience - 5
 - Psyche - 4
 - Strength - 1
 - Intelligence - 2

Get to Know the School

- **Endless Corridors**

The school is full of **Endless Corridors**, that by exploring them, the player will be able to reach the **Rooftop**, the **Library** and to be able to open the path towards the **Science Lab**.

- **Science Lab**

In the Science Lab, the player can defeat the Science Professor. It also unlocks the path to the **Labyrinth**.

- **Library**

In the library, the player has to move quietly to avoid confronting the **Librarian**. The **Library**, has a secret level in which the player delves into the deepest memories of the protagonist. Through the **Library**, the player opens the path to the **Shadow Theater**.

- **Cafeteria**

The **Cafeteria**, is the room in which the player can defeat the **Cook**. Through the Cafeteria, the player can access the **Bathrooms** and the **Recess**.

- **Bathrooms**

When **Irene** and **Sophia** are in the player's party, it unlocks the **Night School**. In addition to this, if the player has the item '**dynamite**', it can be used to access the **Sewers**. It can also be used to unlock the "**Strange Things**" ending.

- **Sewers**

It's the only path to reach **Olivier's Room**.

- **Olivier's Room**

In Olivier's Room, the player faces the decision of:

- Taking the gun, unlocking the "**Inner Demons**" ending.
- Confronting Olivier, unlocking the "**A Look Into the Abyss**" ending and **The Abyss**.

- **Labyrinth**

The **Labyrinth**, is like the **Endless Corridors** but much more distorted and twisted. It conveys the decision to go deeper into the conscious fears of the protagonist. The sensation of being lost and disoriented.

The **Labyrinth** leads to **The Abyss** and to **Olivier's Room**.

- **The Abyss**

This location is the deepest level of the fears of the protagonist. In **The Abyss**, lay the deepest and unconscious fears. Here, the ambience is pitch black, forcing the player to have a source of light to navigate through it. Darkness, as in the "**Nightmare**" difficulty, inflicts stress damage to the character.

In **The Abyss**, the player is able to fight the incarnation of Fear itself and unlock the "**Shanti**" ending.

- **Playground**

The **Playground**, is the place on the map infested with enemies. It's full of horrors and avoids the player to leave the school.

The **Playground** leads to the **Gym**, the **Shadow Theater** during the “**Daily Basics**” difficulty mode. During the “**Nightmare**” difficulty mode, the player is also able to access the **Director's Office**.

- **Gym**

The **Gym**, is the only location in which the player is able to face the school bullies.

- **Shadow Theater**

The **Shadow Theater** is the location to unlock the “**True Ending**” ending. It symbolizes that the player is merely a puppet controlled by fear. It also unlocks the “**A Terrible Fate**” endings. In which the player gets completely controlled by fear.

- **Night School**

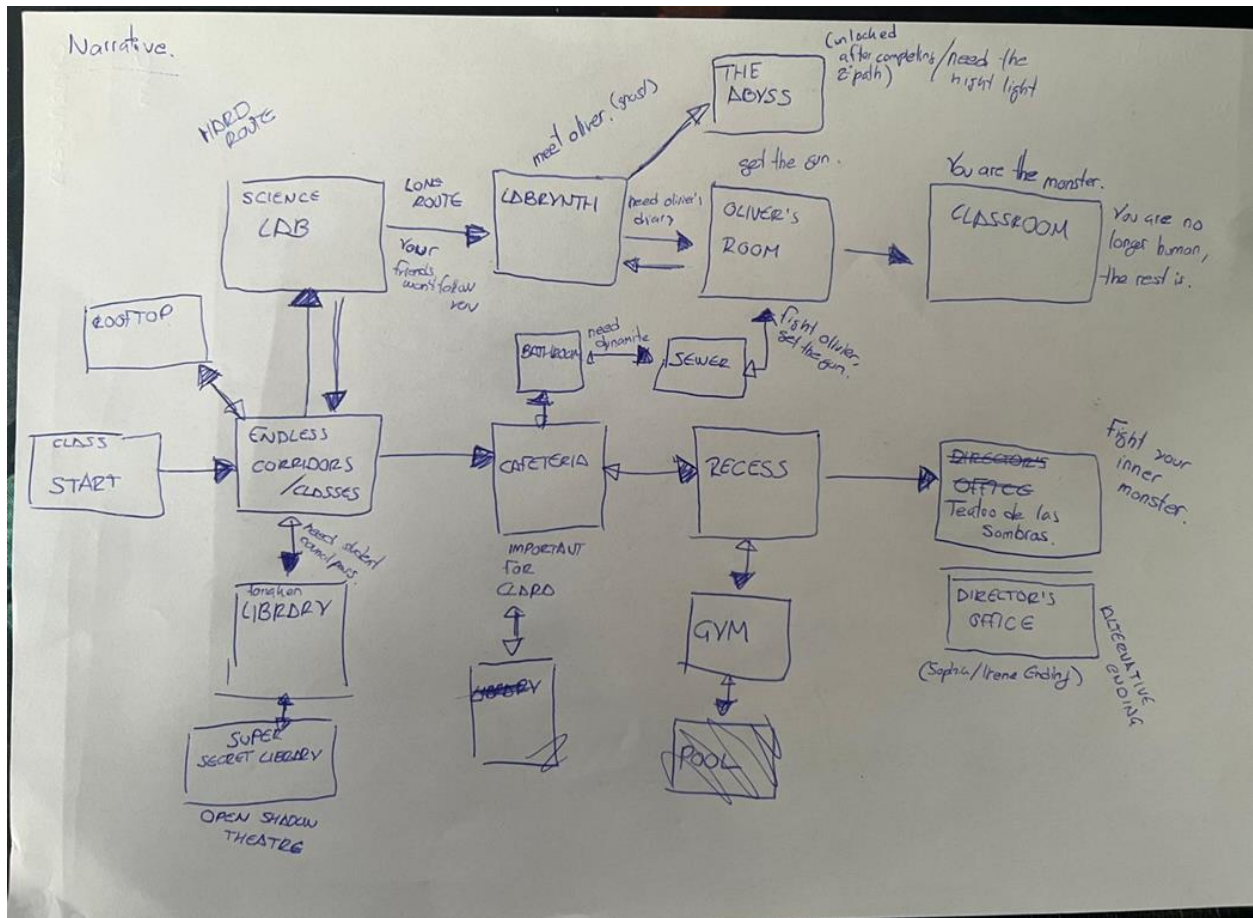
During the night, the school is guarded by the Janitor. Also, this unlocks the **Headmaster's Office**.

- **Headmaster's Office**

In this location, the player can face the Headmaster.

- **Rooftop**

In the **Rooftop**, the player unlocks the alternative ending of **Clara** and unlocks the character **Irene**. Also, the Rooftop unlocks the “**A Quick Solution**” ending.



Get to Know the Bosses

- **Mad Scientist**

This boss is located in the **Science Lab**. It fights using chemicals that inflict states such as poison to the characters. Once defeated, it will drop acid to the floor, burning a whole through the ground that connects with the **Labyrinth**.

- **The Cristal Maiden**

This boss is located in the **Rooftop**. It is how Clara sees herself, as an abomination, fat.

- **The Librarian**

This boss is located in the **Library**. It is obsessed with following the rules and will punish those who break the silence. It will not attack the player unless he is spotted by an enemy. Very important for Sophia's lore.

- **Incarnation of Fear**

This boss is located in the **Abyss**. It will embody the fears of the protagonist and his group, changing between four forms during the fight.

- **The Puppeteer**

This boss is located in the **Shadow Theatre**. It represents the idea of being controlled by fear. It does not confront the player itself; it will command puppets to fight for it.

- **The Cook**

This boss is located in the **Cafeteria**. It deals great physical damage and inflicts bleed effect. Very important for Clara's lore.

- **The Bullies**

This boss is located in the **Playground**. If you defeat it, it will run away to the **Gym**, where the player will have to face the boss and the leader. This boss consists of several enemies. If you defeat the leader, the rest of the group will run away. Very important for Sam's lore.

- **The Headmaster**

This boss is located in the **Headmaster's office**. It will try to force Sophia to join her side during combat. It has great Intelligence stats. Very important for Sophia and Irene's lore.

- **The Janitor**

This boss is located at the **School at Night**. It will patrol the corridors. If it sees the player, it will start to chase the player.

- **Unleashed Spirit**

This boss is located in **Olivier's Room**. It is Olivier's will of vengeance. It will attack you if you decide not to take the gun, or if you get to the room through the **Sewers**.

Some of the Endings

During the development of the game, the team came up with some ideas for the different endings for the game.

- **True Ending:** Go to the **Shadow Theater** and defeat your mirror self. Unlocks the difficulty mode “**Nightmare**” and the personality “**Freed**”. To get to this ending the player has to follow a specific path to unlock it.
- **A Terrible Fate:** Go to the **Shadow Theater** and defeat your mirror self. Unlocks the difficulty mode “**Nightmare**” and the personality “**Possessed**”. The protagonist gets overwhelmed by fear and completely loses control of himself. To get to this ending the player has to follow a specific path to unlock it.
- **Inner Demons:** Get **Olivier's** shotgun.
This ending unlocks the item “**dynamite**” to be used to access the **Sewers** and the **Labyrinth**. Also, unlocks the personality “**Penitent**”.
- **A Look Into the Abyss:** Confronting Olivier.
This ending unlocks the item “**dynamite**” to be used to access the **Sewers** and the **Labyrinth**. Also, unlocks the personality “**True Self**”.
- **Shanti:** Enter **The Abyss** and defeat Fear. Unlocks the difficulty mode “**Boss Rush**” and the personality “**Resilient**”.
- **Martyr:** To unlock this ending, the player must let 3 allies die and do the “**True Ending**” route. In this ending, the player faces both versions of the protagonist, not knowing who he is anymore. It also unlocks the “**The Imaginary Friend**”.
- **Strange Things:** When **Irene** and **Sophia** are in the players party, the **Bathrooms** will let the player hide until it gets dark in the school and sneak into the **Principal's Office**. This will allow the player to face the **Principal** and unlock the personality “**The Hidden One**”.
- **One for All:** When **Olivier** and **Sam** are in the players party, confront the group of bullies at the **Gym**. The player will have to decide:
 - Spare their life. Representing Redemption.
 - Finish them off. Representing Revenge.After completing it, the player unlocks the personality “**Rampaged**”.
- **The Push off the Cliff:** If **Clara** is on the players party and is on her maximum size, the player can confront **Clara** on the **Rooftop**. The player has to decide:

- Not fighting **Clara**. Representing the sacrifice for the loved ones and unlocking the secret ending “**You Love those Whom you Give**” and the secret self “**Fulfilled**”.
- Fighting **Clara**. Representing the survival of the strongest.
- **You Love those to Whom you Give**: This ending can only be unlocked by not fighting **Clara** in the “**The Push off the Cliff**” ending.
- **A Quick Solution**: The main character jumps from the roof.

Progression Design

Combat Progression

As the level progresses, the player can choose to upgrade the protagonist stats, unlocking new skills. For example, moving up in **Psyche** might allow him to access more powerful skills or mind control abilities, while increasing **Strength** would improve his ability to inflict physical damage. This progression is clear, with enough flexibility for the player to customize their play style.

To increase the difficulty level, the level of enemies and the complexity of combat is progressively increasing, challenging the player to constantly adapt. This may also involve enemies becoming smarter and using more complex tactics as the player progresses, while maintaining an appropriate level of challenge for the player. Making the game more challenging, less recursive and more engaging and rewarding.

Narrative Progression

The main character must evolve throughout the game, not only in terms of statistics, but also on a personal and emotional level. As he progresses through the story, he can gain new abilities that reflect his growth, either through facing his own fears or by helping other characters along the way.

Since the NPCs are an important part of Through Their Eyes narrative, NPCs evolve throughout the game, like the main character, reflecting how the player's interaction with them affects their stories. NPCs may offer side quests, but they may also provide valuable resources or skills that directly affect gameplay.

Because of this characters development, the game world expands as the player progresses, unlocking new areas, events, characters and enemies that deepen the story and gameplay. Discoveries made during exploration should have a visible impact on the narrative.

Replayability

Game content will be added progressively as the player becomes immersed in the game's narrative and completes challenges. Expanding new routes available, as well as new objects and characters that not only add more layers to the narrative but make for a more varied and complete game experience.

Challenges and Difficulty

Thanks to the choice of narrative, the challenges that are proposed to the player have been given in numerous ways. One of them is through the narrative, where the player is put to empathize with the fear that the protagonist suffers every day, with the mixture of social anxiety and a self-destructive imagination. Creating a concoction that pushes the player's discomfort to the limit. To solve this, the player will be able to develop the levels into numerous endings that will either help or further isolate the protagonist. In order to reach the end of these and discover all the fates that await him, there will be requirements for certain branches of the story, which will force the player to develop the protagonist's abilities so that he himself can face his fears.

The final example of challenge is that the player is put into situations where interaction with NPCs can develop in a way that either gains an ally or an enemy to face. This turns dialogue and combat into puzzles that the player has to solve as the story progresses. This leads to the next point, the challenges during combat.

During combat, the complexity is that the damage system has been divided into two: physical damage and stress damage. In case of receiving the maximum points the character has, the character will be given a condition that negatively affects the character. If not treated in time, this condition will worsen and have consequences during combat.

Finally, to adjust the difficulty of the game, four types of gameplay have been added. The first of these is 'Daily Basics', which will be the normal game mode. In this mode, the story will unfold at the speed of the player's choice with no conditions or gameplay restrictions. As a second option and to give more emphasis to the combat mechanics, the 'Nightmare' game mode has been created. In this option, the player will visit the school during the night. This will result in the player taking stress damage if they walk in the dark along the corridors and rooms they encounter. In order to solve it, there will be numerous options. For example: finding the 'lantern' object that will allow the player to light up the room in front of him in the form of a cone.

The third game mode that will be offered to the player will be ‘School Day’, which will consist of a time trial to finish the level. This mode refers to the experience of a whole day at school, where the start and end times are fixed. And finally, ‘The Quick Way’ game mode. This last game mode is the most hostile of the four. It consists of facing the game's bosses in a single level, meaning that the player forces the protagonist to face all his fears without having travelled the path at the usual pace.

Difficulty Curve

Challenging Start

From the beginning, the difficulty of the game is designed to be slightly above the player's level, encouraging learning and adaptation to the basic mechanics. This approach ensures that players perceive the challenge from the start, but with sufficient tools to overcome it. At the beginning of every run, the character's stats are fixed, thus under level.

Progressive Scaling with the Narrative

As the player progresses, he acquires allies, skills and items that balance the difficulty, allowing him to face more complex challenges. This growth ensures that the player feels that he is improving not only in terms of stats, but also in his mastery of the game. Each time the player advances to a new area or defeats a boss, the difficulty increases. This is reflected in more complex enemies, additional mechanics and environmental challenges that require adaptations in strategy. So even experienced players still find a challenge playing the game.

Difficulty Spikes

Boss fights and major narrative events are the highest points of difficulty. These confrontations are designed to test all the skills the player has acquired up to that point, offering a sense of accomplishment upon overcoming them.

Beyond battles, key narrative events can present unexpected challenges, such as changes in map conditions, allies in danger, or difficult decisions with immediate consequences. These events represent the peaks of narrative difficulty, engaging the player with morally charged choices.

Variation in Route Difficulty

Some routes within the game present a higher level of challenge than others. The player must evaluate his current level and resources to decide which path to take. This choice adds a strategic element, where risk can be linked to more valuable rewards.

Stability and Experience Scaling

As the player gets better at the game, new content and randomized map and item generation ensure that the difficulty remains stable. This prevents the game from becoming predictable or too easy, while maintaining a challenging experience. The introduction of new enemies, status effects and conditions in advanced areas ensures that the difficulty adjusts organically to the player's progress.

Challenges for Experienced Players

Randomization of maps, objects and enemies ensures that every game remains a challenge. Unexpected combinations of enemies and events keep the game's difficulty stable. For players looking for an additional challenge, higher difficulty modes or specific challenges, designed to make the most of their knowledge of the game, can be unlocked. These challenges change the gameplay dynamics, offering players a new experience. In addition to In-Game challenges, players can come up with their own challenge ideas, such as completing a run by only leveling one stat. This also contributes to forging a stronger community, sharing these challenges with other people.

Explanation of Genre Hybridization

When blending the genres of Narrative Adventure and Roguelike, specific mechanics were taken from both genres to strengthen the narrative and combat. To make both genres nurture each other in a beneficial way, it was decided that turn-based combat would be the glue to keep everything flowing smoothly and coherently.

From the Narrative Adventures, it was decided that Through Their Eyes needed to be narrative-heavy. This is achieved through alternate paths through the procedurally generated levels and a dynamic narrative, which adapts to the style of play and the player's decisions. It is precisely because of this that the narrative is given the weight it seeks to create. In addition, since it has been chosen to add turn-based combat, the battles become puzzles that add narrative and gameplay depth.

Finally, it uses the Roguelike mechanic that when the player dies, the level restarts. This mechanic is perfect for adding and strengthening the weight of the narrative, as it becomes a unique experience for each game. The choices the player makes are much more impactful, as there is no turning back and the level will unfold in different ways each walkthrough.

In short, efforts have been focused on the narrative, but without losing the dynamism of the gameplay and combat. The final experience is a game that encourages exploration, decision making and combat that helps to better understand the environment and immerse oneself more in the story. The coherence between the two genres is provided by combat and exploration. Turn-based combat between characters, exploration to unravel all the intricacies of the school and the story that the game gives, and a reason for each decision that the player makes, avoiding the feeling of recursion and, thus, achieving a balanced game.

Game Monetization

For monetization, the game is intended to be a 'Pay to play' game. This consists of delivering a finished game for which the customer pays only once and can enjoy the full experience.

This has been decided as the idea of the game is to have a beginning and an end. Therefore, it does not make sense to add another monetization method.

Monetization elements

- Digital copy of the game

A normal version of the game that includes the base game in digital format.

- Deluxe Edition

A Deluxe version, for people who want to support the project a little more or have everything that is offered in the initial version. This version will add a copy of the game and will include a number of exclusive character skins lore related, which will not add anything outside the visual aspect. In addition, the original soundtrack of the game.

- Collector's Edition

This version will only exist in physical form and will have a limited number of units for added exclusivity. It will include a digital copy of the base game, the skins included in the Deluxe version plus an exclusive Collector's Edition, the original soundtrack on CD and digital, a physical copy of the artbook and a box that will package the content. Something similar to the 'Death's Door' or 'Gris' editions.

- Skins

Throughout the development of future expansions, skin and cosmetic packs will be created for players who want to further customize their characters.

- DLCs and short stories

These will nourish the background of the main character, as well as his friends or other NPCs the player encounters through the game.

Impact of including these elements

Thanks to all these forms of monetization, it will foster the development of a community that expects the game they have invested in to be further developed and cared for. In turn, they can expect the product they buy to be finished and to contain further story and narrative development. This will result in a game with little or no noticeable bugs except in specific situations, and a more polished game. Likewise, thanks to all the above, in case there are bugs that may impede the normal development of the experience, the user can rely on that the studio puts effort, dedication and love to provide the best possible experience and will try to fix them as soon as possible. This will strengthen the trust placed in the studio and its members in the future and may increase the number of sales of future releases.

Finally, by offering different versions of the game, it will help the user to feel more involved in the creation of the game as well as in the financial support offered to the studio. With the bonus of feeling the exclusivity of having additions to the game that not many of its users will opt for.

Level Design

Shadow Theatre Boss Fight.

The protagonist walks into a theater room with the lights off. There are enemies sitting in the seats staring at the stage, but they are not hostile. Approach the seemingly empty stage with the curtain down. The player is given the option to start the show. If the player hits no he will get off the stage and have time to organize the team.

If the protagonist chooses yes, the curtain will rise and a spotlight will illuminate where the player is. When the curtain rises completely the player will see a puppet similar to his own, controlled by ropes falling from above.

This puppet represents the figure of the protagonist being a mere puppet controlled by fear. A combat in which you will face this figure will begin.

The difficulty of this combat is that the enemy you face has your same stats and abilities, but with more life. So the stronger the player is, the stronger the boss will be.

The Puppeteer has several abilities that inflict fear on allies. One of them being a unique ability of this one, able to inflict fear ignoring the Resilience level of the characters. The puppet cannot be inflicted with any primary status condition.

Another unique mechanic of this combat is the following: During the fight the final boss can use the ability “Threads of Betrayal” which allows him to control one of your allies and use them against you. But he can only use this ability on a character with the Fear status or its evolution. Characters controlled by the Puppeteer cannot be inflicted with status conditions.

These will pass to the opposite side, controlled by strings just like the puppet. You will no longer have control of that character, and it will now fight against you.

You can regain control of the allies by hitting the hand that controls them. It has its own life bar and stats. Once defeated, it will release the character and return to you.

Another option is to defeat your ally in combat. Leaving the player without an ally for the rest of the combat, but in return the Puppeteer will not be able to control him against you.

Defeating an ally in combat has a chance to cause a random primary altered state in your allies.

The fight has two phases.

Once the life of the puppet has reached 0. The puppet will collapse to the ground, and after a couple of seconds, another monstrous puppet will fall from above, crushing the previous one. The puppet has now become a deformed version of yourself, a true monster. It incarnates the concept of how you see reality within yourself.

If the protagonist is facing the puppet alone in combat, it will be inflicted with fear, unless the player is playing with the “True Self” character, which is immune to fear. This puppet is significantly larger and is divided into 3 parts: the two arms and the head. The head has increased health.

To defeat the puppet, the player must make the life bar of the head reach 0.

But trying to weaken the arms might be a good strategy, as the puppet now has strong damage abilities, some of them are AoE (Area of Effect attacks, meaning it deals damage to more than one target).

The Puppeteer can no longer use his ability “Threads of Betrayal”, as all his hands are focused on the giant puppet. But instead, the puppet has new and stronger abilities.

Endings

If you manage to defeat the Puppeteer, a cinematic will start in which the strings will fall to the ground, releasing the puppet. The previous puppet will emerge from under the monter. This will start a cheer, the puppet will wave to the stage and approach the protagonist, take him by the hand and escort him to the exit, towards the real world, while the curtain closes behind him. This concludes the story.

In the case of not being able to defeat him, a cinematic will start in which the Puppeteer traps all the allies including the protagonist and will control them at his own will. Making the player see that they have not been able to overcome their fears and that they now control them. The show must go on.

The Library

The library is one of the rooms necessary to complete the True Ending route and Sophia’s story.

At first glance, it appears to be a peaceful room. Upon entering, the player will find themselves in a room filled with bookshelves. They will also notice some enemies wandering the area or staring at the shelves.

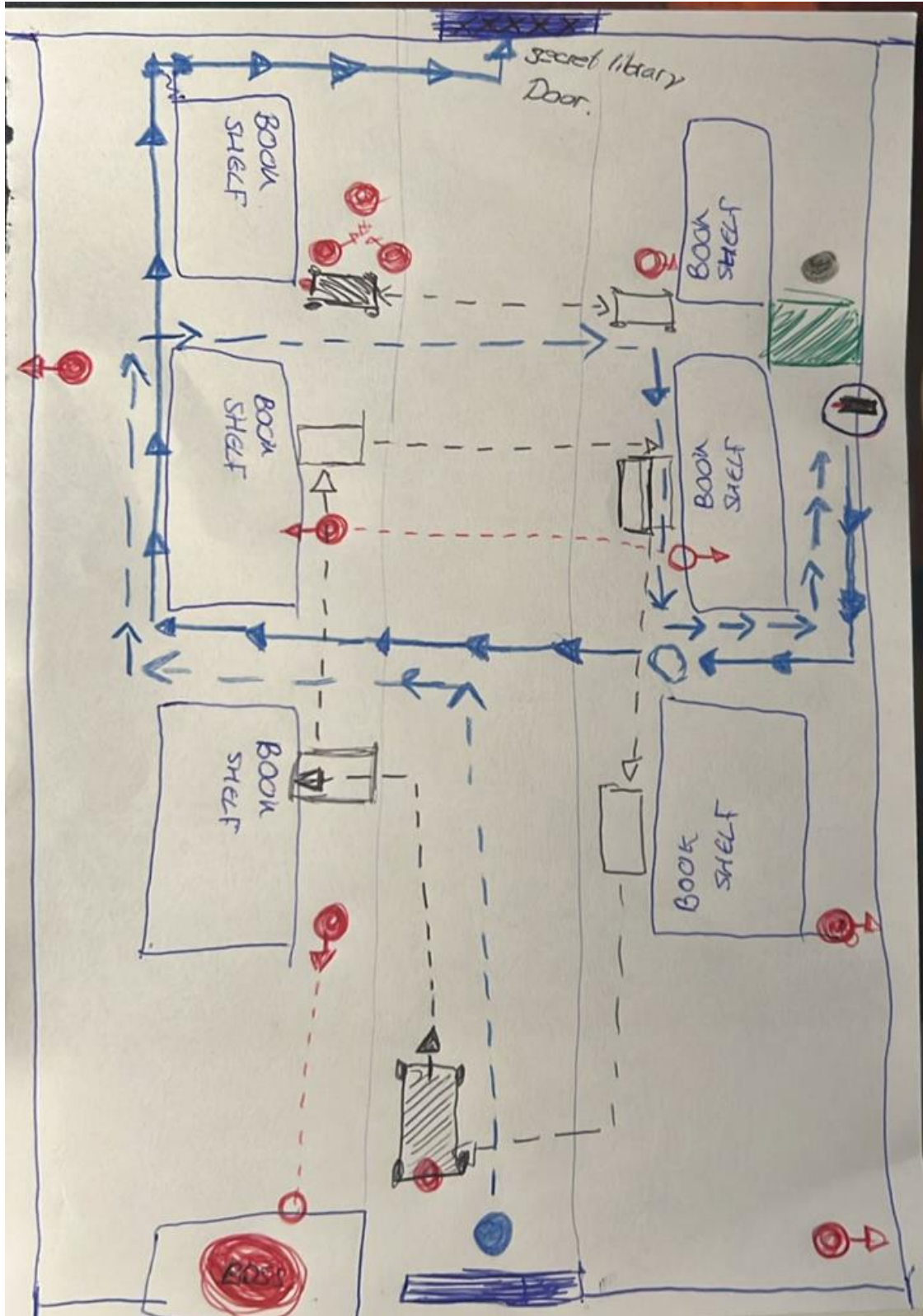
To the left of the door is the reception desk, where the Librarian ensures that all conduct protocols are followed.

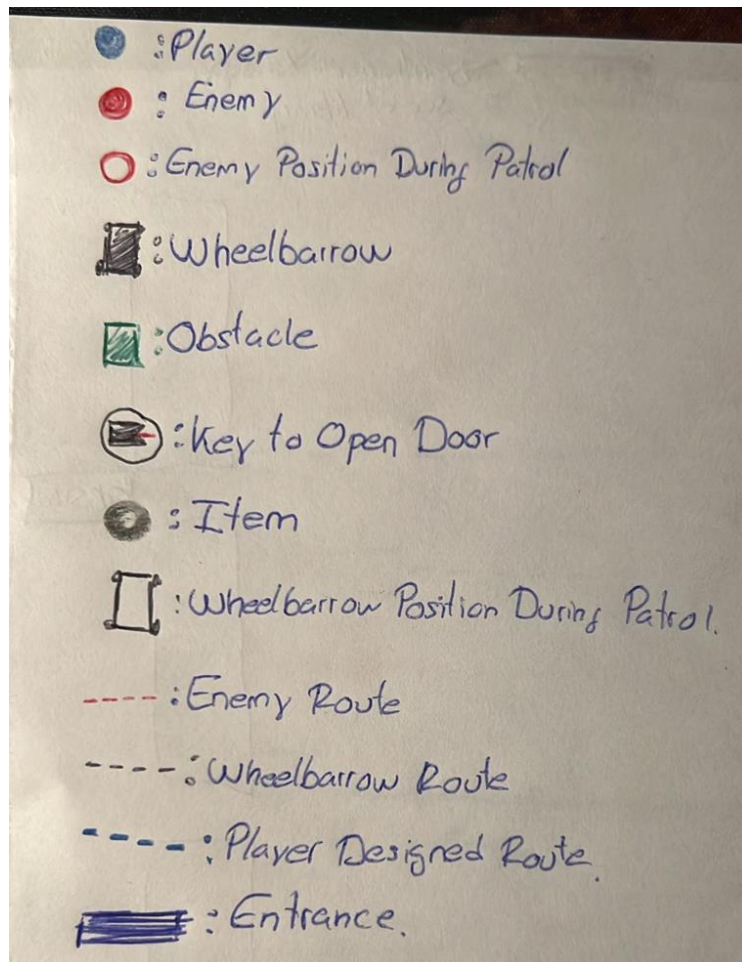
This enemy is not hostile towards the player and their group. As long as the player follows the rules, the Librarian will not consider them a threat.

The player will need to navigate through the room, avoiding enemies to prevent making noise. Alerting an enemy will attract the Librarian's attention, triggering a boss fight.

To avoid being seen, the player will need to make use of their surroundings, such as carts that follow a set route to replenish books on the shelves, or by studying the enemies' movements and analyzing the best moments to advance.

The following image shows a diagram of how the level would look, marking in blue the most optimal path the player could take, along with a legend for better understanding.





At the end of the room, the player will be able to obtain a hidden item behind one of the bookshelves, rewarding those who decide to explore the room more thoroughly.

To access the Super-Secret Library, the player must find the book "The Archive of Forgotten Truths," referring to the room where they store their forgotten truths (secrets).

Since this is not a puzzle or stealth-focused game, the level should not be too challenging for the player, as that could lead to frustration. The goal is for the level to contribute to the narrative, making the player feel like they need to advance quietly. Even if the player is detected, it is not the end of the game. They will have to face a powerful enemy, the Librarian, but if they manage to defeat her, they can proceed through the room with greater safety, as only common enemies remain.

The Abyss

The Abyss is one of the final areas you can reach by descending into the labyrinth. It symbolizes delving into the deepest feelings of the protagonist. This area is engulfed in absolute darkness and silence, with the only light coming from will-o'-the-wisps that provide a faint glow in small areas throughout the labyrinthine corridors of the Abyss. There are no enemies in this area, but characters will suffer stress damage if they are not in a lit area. The will-o'-the-wisps will extinguish once you leave them behind, leaving nothing but emptiness, so you can only move forward. If a character remains too long outside a lit area, they will receive the primary altered state of fear. Characters with fear of the dark will be more prone to being inflicted with fear in dark areas.

If the player equips items like the Lantern or Nightlight, which emit light, they can advance through the darkness without fear of being affected by the altered state. These items will make it easier for the player to progress. If the player advances into a dead-end and does not carry a light-emitting item, they must backtrack through the darkness to find the path lit by will-o'-the-wisps. They must hurry and be careful not to get lost in the Abyss, or their soul will be trapped forever... and it will be the end of the game.

If the player reaches the heart of the Abyss, they must face the Incarnation of Fear in a battle.

The Incarnation of Fear takes various forms throughout the battle. These forms are physical representations of the protagonist's and their allies' greatest fears. If a character takes direct damage from an attack by the Incarnation of Fear, they will receive the state of Despair.

The first form represents the fear of collective judgment, the voices of those who criticize, observe, or torment the protagonist.

This form consists of a formless mass of agonizing faces that scream and whisper, judging the characters.

It stands out for its high Psyche value and will attempt to destroy the characters' morale by inflicting stress damage with abilities like Cacophony of Sorrow, unleashing a blood-curdling scream that damages characters in an area with a chance to inflict stun, or Echo of Regret, dealing damage to a single character, reducing their resilience.

The second form represents the fear of an authoritative figure, the feeling of inferiority. This colossal figure has a more humanoid appearance. However, its large size and posture are intimidating.

This form excels in strength. It focuses on physical abilities such as devastating melee attacks and area sweeps like Crushing Edict, striking the ground forcefully, creating a shockwave that damages and stuns nearby players, or Reign of Authority, marking a character, inflicting the Marked state, and forcing them to remain in place for 3 turns unless they dodge. Hitting an ally under the effect of this ability will break the trance and return them to their senses, ending the effect.

The third form represents the fear of the inevitable, an immovable force. This figure, resembling an Iron Maiden, stands out for its exceptional Resilience stat. Its great resistance to damage makes it quite tanky, along with its ability Immutable Force, which returns a percentage of the damage received to the attacker. This, together with its other ability Shadows of the Fallen, creates shadow clones of the allies to fight against your team. These clones have reduced health. They will vanish if illuminated by light.

The last form represents the fear of loneliness. This form, which excels in intelligence, will cover the entire battlefield with darkness, isolating the characters on its turn, meaning they will not be able to see their allies or cast support abilities on them. It also has very high evasion, making it difficult to hit unless the player carries a light-emitting item. This will reveal what is in the darkness (a terrifying silhouette) and reduce its evasion. This form will try to surprise your team and cause altered states.

ENDINGS

If you defeat the Incarnation of Fear, the player will enter a cinematic where the boss merges with the shadows, fading away. Shortly after, a path lit by will-o'-the-wisps will guide the group towards the exit.

If you fail to defeat it in battle, the player will enter a cinematic, in which, depending on which form defeated the player, the contents of the cinematic will vary.

The first form will engulf the characters, and new faces will appear on its body. The second will crush the characters with its foot. The third will plunge everything into darkness, condemning the characters to wander in solitude in the darkness. The last will open the Iron Maiden's door, locking the characters inside.